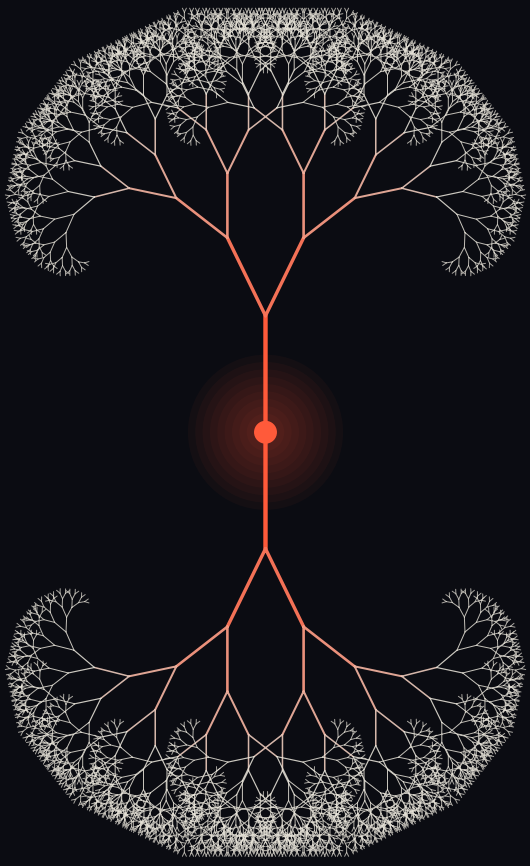
The Source



A vision of consciousness, infinity and return

The Source

A vision of consciousness, infinity and return

One shared origin, two infinities, countless lives, and a return. Twenty-one ideas for holding consciousness, death and meaning together. Everything rests on one postulate: each consciousness would be part of a single consciousness, and the rest follows. One difference from the great traditions before it: this origin would not itself know why it exists. This is metaphysics: a vision to explore and to challenge, not a scientific theory.

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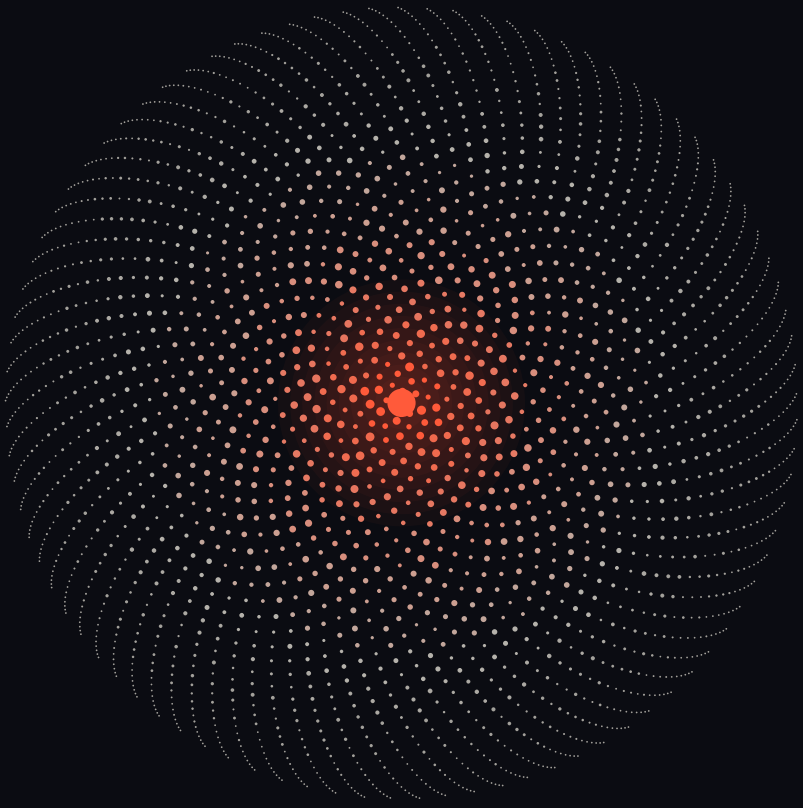
Glossary

A few words come back from one chapter to the next. Here is the sense they take in this book.

Source	The shared origin of everything that exists, which discovers itself by existing.
Fractal	A shape that repeats the same pattern at every scale.
Soul	A vaster consciousness that gathers several lives.
Unfolding	The movement by which the Source takes form in worlds and lives.
Experience	What no knowledge replaces: going through something once, without knowing what comes next.
Freedom	The part of a life no one dictates, since no one, not even the Source, knows what comes next.
Balance	The never-settled equilibrium between all the polarities of what is lived.
Return	Joining the whole and bringing to it what was lived.
Form	A particular, and passing, way of being alive.

The echoes after each chapter prove nothing. They only show that these questions are very old, and that others have asked them differently.

Everything starts from one point, and everything returns to it.



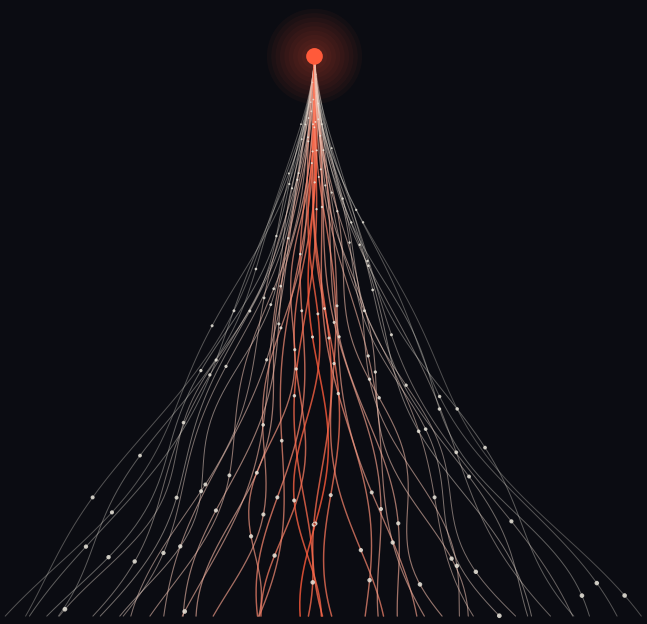
A river can be followed back to a trickle of water between two stones. The intuition is the same at the scale of everything that exists: follow consciousnesses, worlds and matter back to a shared origin. That is what the Source names here. Some would call it God, and the word matters less than the idea.

This origin would not stand above the world looking on. Nor would it hold every answer from the start: it would discover what it is as things come to exist, from within, through each point of view.

Existing would be its way of learning what it is.

This is not the usual picture. We often imagine the origin as an architect: someone who knows in advance what they are building, sets the pieces one by one and contemplates the result. Here there is no prior plan. The image would rather be that of a musician who improvises and only discovers the melody by playing it. Each note counts, precisely because none was written.

One may object that it is simpler to do without it. The world exists, it obeys laws, and nothing forces us to suppose an origin that would also be a consciousness. The objection is serious, and this book does not claim to refute it. It makes another wager: to take seriously the fact that consciousness exists, that there is someone to see rather than a silent mechanism, and to ask what the whole would be if it were, from end to end, of that nature.



A scene may help. A child asks where they were before they were born. The usual answer is: nowhere. This vision offers another answer, no better proven but one that changes how we look: they were already there, in another form, as the water of a river was already water before it ran between these particular banks.

The image of the river stops there, because water does not flow back to its source. Here, everything would return. Three movements organise what follows: unfolding, experience, return.

These three movements do not follow one another like the chapters of a story. They happen at once, everywhere, at every

scale: something is born, something lives, something returns. And the Source would discover itself in each of these passages.

Echoes

Plotinus, *Enneads*, 3rd century. Everything proceeds from the One, and everything longs to turn back toward it.

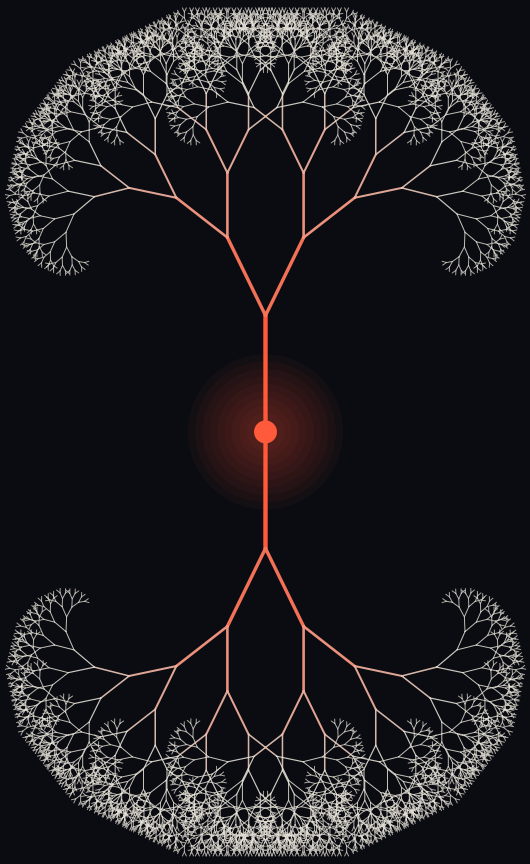
Hegel, *Phenomenology of Spirit*, 1807. The absolute is not given at the outset: Spirit becomes what it is by discovering itself through history.

What remains open

If the Source is the origin of everything, where does it come from?

Two infinities are born from one point.

infinitely large



infinitely small

A fractal repeats one pattern at every scale. Imagine two of them, born from one point. One opens toward the infinitely large: galaxies, clusters, universes, perhaps others still. The other descends toward the infinitely small: cells, atoms, particles, ever deeper levels.

The Source stands at their junction. It is neither the largest nor the smallest element, but what connects the two directions and gives birth to them.

The two directions do not oppose each other. With a telescope, we find galaxies made of clouds, dust and stars. With a microscope, cells made of molecules, then atoms, then particles we can no longer really picture. In both directions, each level opens onto another, and none seems to be the last.

Everything emerges, everything returns, and everything changes on the way.

This is not only an image. Nature really does repeat patterns at several scales: the branching of a tree resembles that of a river, a lung, a bolt of lightning. These resemblances do not prove that the whole is a fractal. They show that the universe likes to repeat itself, and this vision takes that tendency seriously.

Pascal saw in this cause for vertigo: humanity lost between two abysses, too large for one, too small for the other. This vision keeps the vertigo but changes its meaning. We would not be lost between the two infinities. We would be at the exact place where they meet, since each consciousness would carry within it the point from which everything starts.

The movement resembles breathing. Existence stops being a straight line from a beginning to an end: it becomes a living

fractal, where one principle acts everywhere. And this pattern, as we will see, holds for consciousness too.

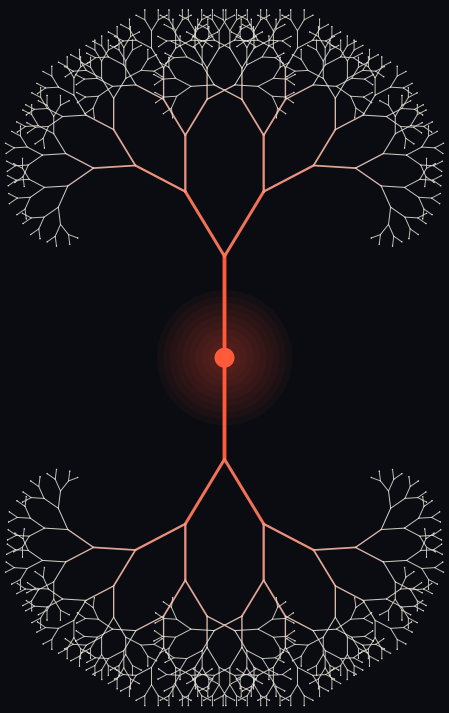
Echoes

Pascal, *Pensées*, 1670. Humanity suspended between two infinities, the infinitely large and the infinitely small.

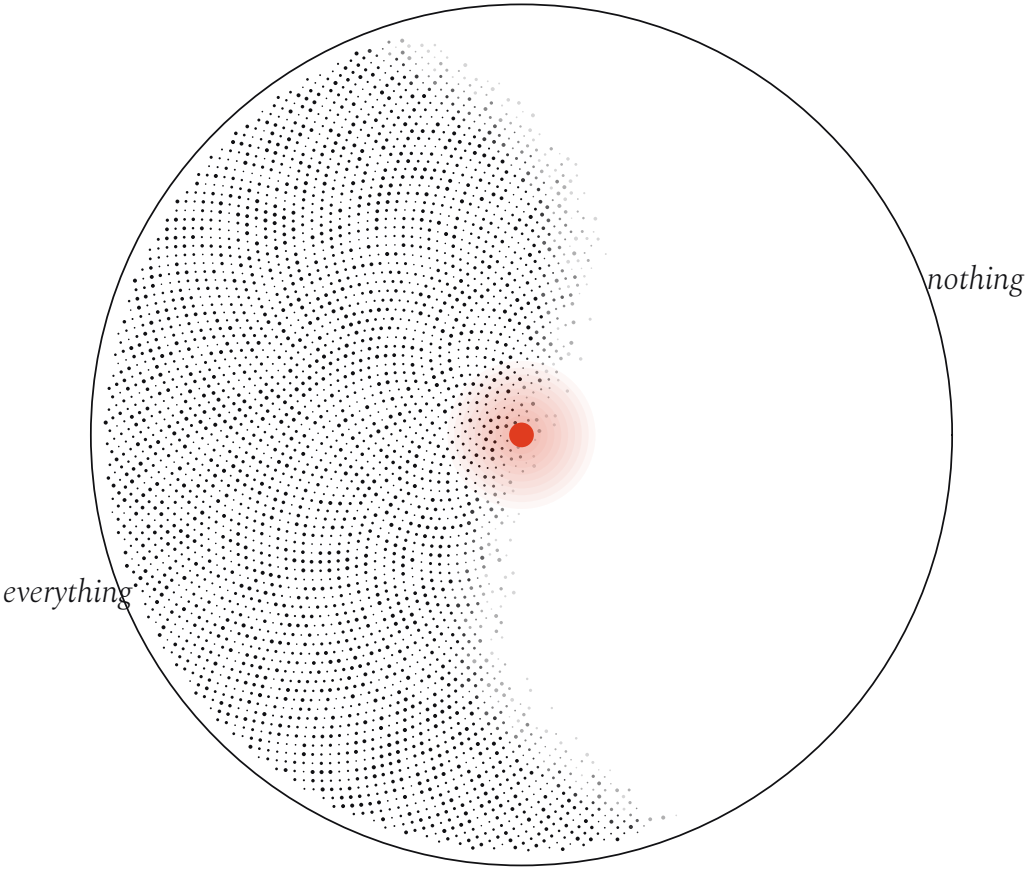
Benoît Mandelbrot, *Les Objets fractals*, 1975. The word fractal, for shapes that repeat at every scale.

What remains open

Nothing shows that the universe is fractal. Does the image illuminate reality, or only how we think about it?



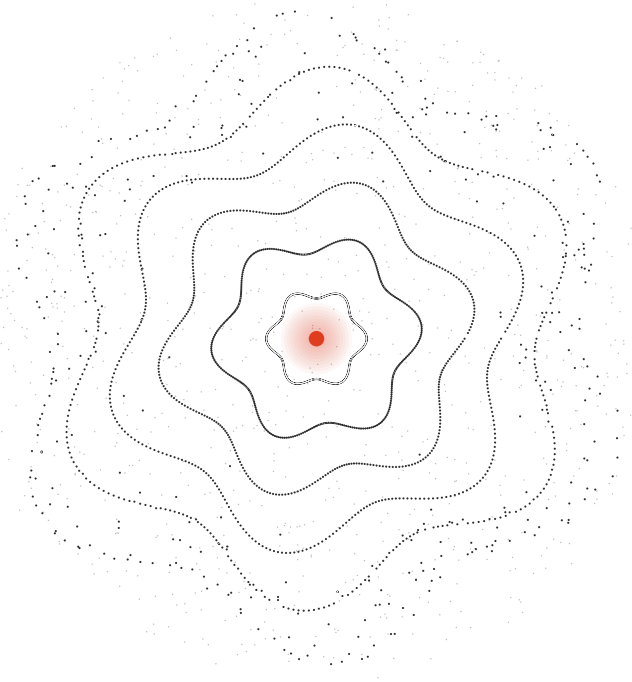
The Source is everything and nothing at once.



Everything, because each universe, consciousness and particle would be an expression of it. Nothing, because before any form it would be no thing in particular.

This nothing is not nonexistence. It is an absence of defined form, a reserve of possibilities, close to what Taoism and non-dual thought have explored.

A blank page is not empty the way a hole is. It contains every possible drawing, precisely because it contains none yet. The silence before a sentence, the stone before the statue, the moment before a decision: each time, the absence of form is also an abundance.



The paradox gives the whole model its engine. Being everything, the Source has nothing to look for outside itself. Being undetermined, it has an infinity of things to discover within.

This double nature explains why the Source is never exhausted. If it were only everything, it would be complete, frozen in its own fullness. If it were only nothing, nothing would happen in it. Nothing calls for forms, and everything welcomes them.

This intuition is found in traditions that did not know one another. The Tao that can be named is not the true Tao, says Laozi. Christian mystics spoke of a God who can only be described by what he is not. Buddhism speaks of emptiness, not to deny the world, but to recall that no form exists alone and forever.

To create is to pass from possibility to experience.

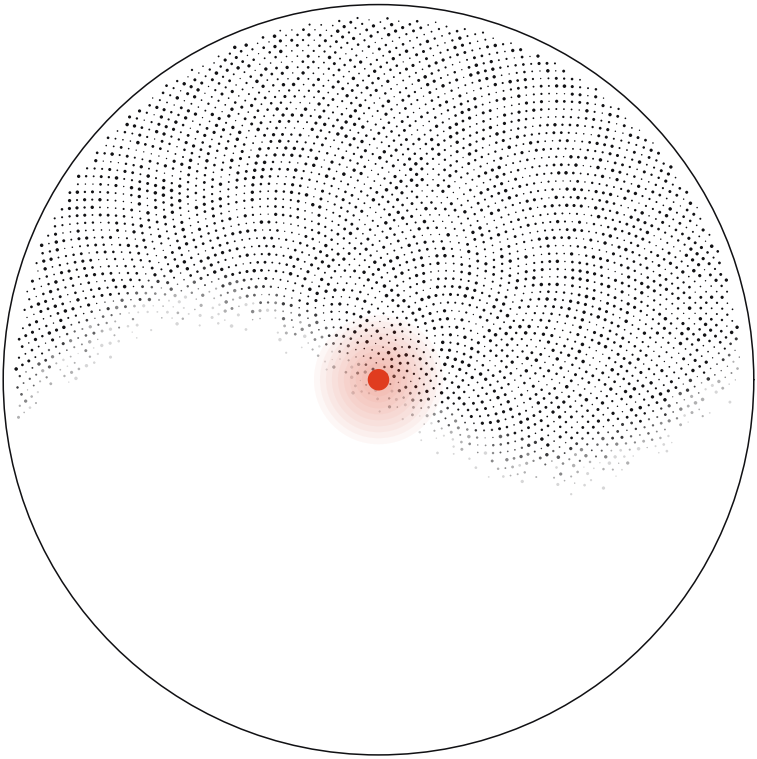
Echoes

Laozi, *Tao Te Ching*. It is the empty centre of the wheel that makes it useful.

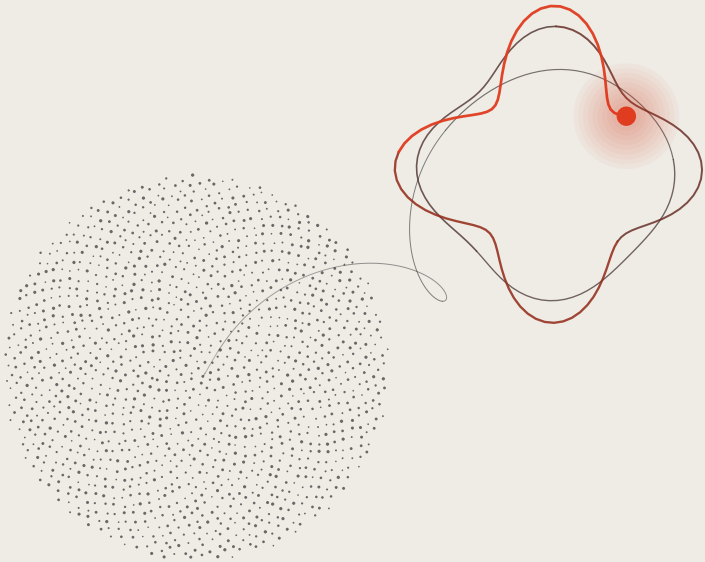
Nicholas of Cusa, *On Learned Ignorance*, 1440. In the infinite, opposites coincide.

What remains open

Can anything be said of an origin that no form defines?



To be born would be to accept being somewhere rather than everywhere.



Everything begins with a limit. Before, there would only be the Source: everything and nothing, without outline. Then a part of it tightens into a point, a body, a gaze, a single pair of eyes. To be born would be this: to consent to being someone, here, now, and not elsewhere.

This limit is not a fall. Ancient stories often see incarnation as an exile: the soul would fall into matter as into a prison. This vision says the opposite. Without limit, no experience is possible. We do not taste a fruit with all mouths at once.

To see something, you have to see it from somewhere.

A newborn does not yet know they are separate. For months, their mother, the light and their own hand form a single world. Separation is learned slowly: one day they discover that the foot they grab is theirs, and that the face leaning over them is not. Each childhood would thus retrace, in miniature, the path from the whole to someone.

What is born would not be drawn at random. This vision supposes that a soul commits to the lives that will teach it what it seeks: this body, this era, these surroundings. This must be said with caution. Nothing allows us to assert it, and the idea becomes dangerous as soon as it is used to tell someone they "chose" their misery or illness. It holds in one sense only: each life would have its reason for being, without anyone being able to read it from outside.

To be born would therefore be less a beginning than a passage. Nothing comes from nowhere: a new form detaches from a ground that was already there, as a wave rises without leaving

the sea. And what begins with a first cry is already, for the whole, a way of saying "I".

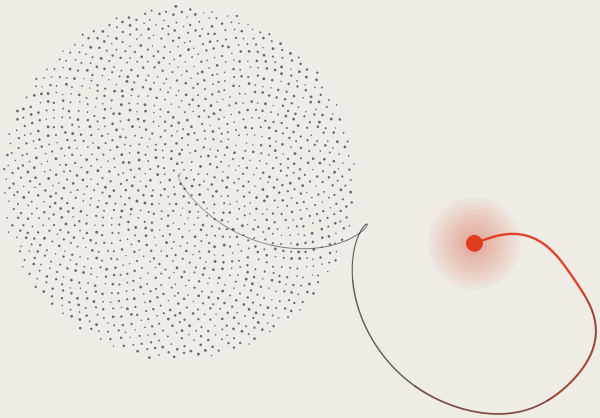
Echoes

Plotinus, *Enneads* IV, 8. The descent of the soul into a body, both necessary and risky.

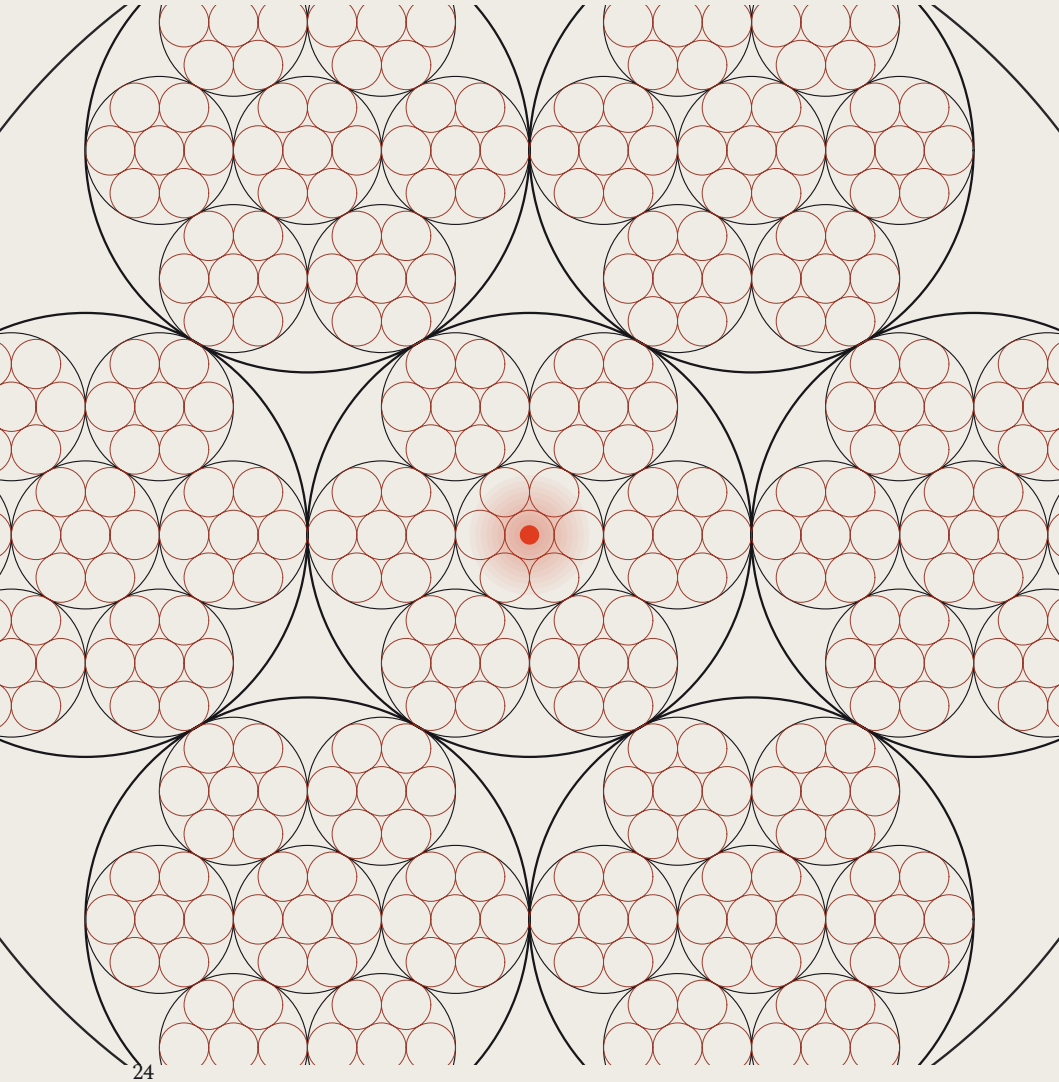
Donald Winnicott, *Playing and Reality*, 1971. At first, the infant distinguishes neither itself nor the world: separation is built up little by little.

What remains open

If each life has its reason for being, what of those that end almost at once? This vision has no answer that does not ring false.



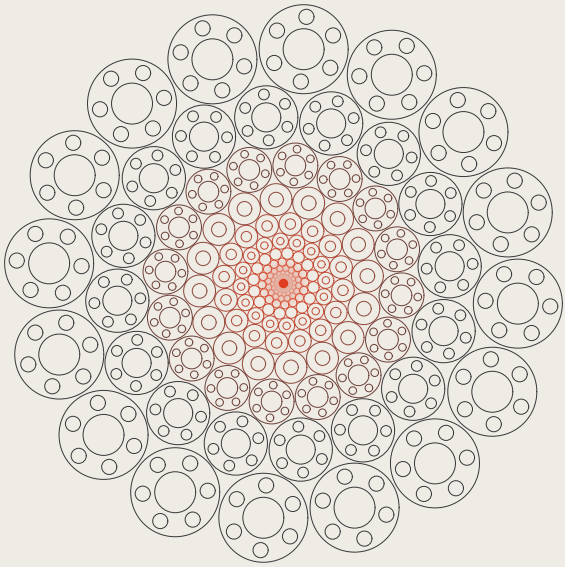
There is no clear border between the individual and the whole.



The pattern repeats at each level. A life belongs to a vaster consciousness, which we can call a soul. That soul belongs to a vaster one still, and so on up to the Source.

Wider does not mean better. No level is worth more than another: each is a different way of looking at the same thing.

We can already see it at our own scale. A cell has a life of its own, and yet it belongs to an organ, which belongs to a body. That body belongs to a family, a city, a species, a living planet. At each level, something acts as a whole, and at the same time as a part. No one has ever found the floor where this stops.



These levels do not crush one another. A soul does not think in place of the lives it gathers, any more than a body decides in place of its cells. Each level has its own way of seeing. The whole would not be a chief, but a choir.

Where does the individual end, and universal consciousness begin?

The question may have no clear-cut answer. There would then be a single consciousness, discovering itself through an infinity of points of view, none of which stops being unique.

This also changes how we see ourselves. What we call "I" would already be a community: billions of cells, inherited memories, inner voices that do not always agree. Being someone would not mean being a block, but a temporary harmony. And what holds within would hold without.

Echoes

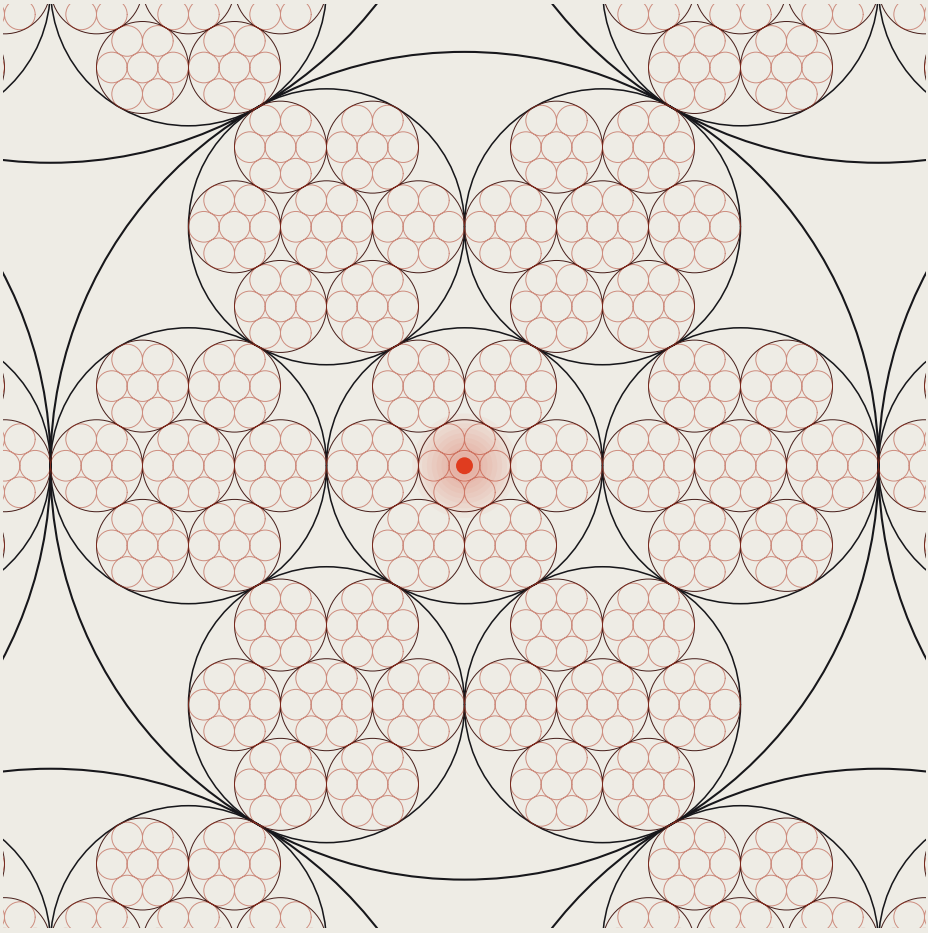
Arthur Koestler, *The Ghost in the Machine*, 1967. The holon: everything that exists is at once a whole and part of a larger whole.

Indra's net, Huayan Buddhism, 7th century. An endless net in which each jewel reflects all the others.

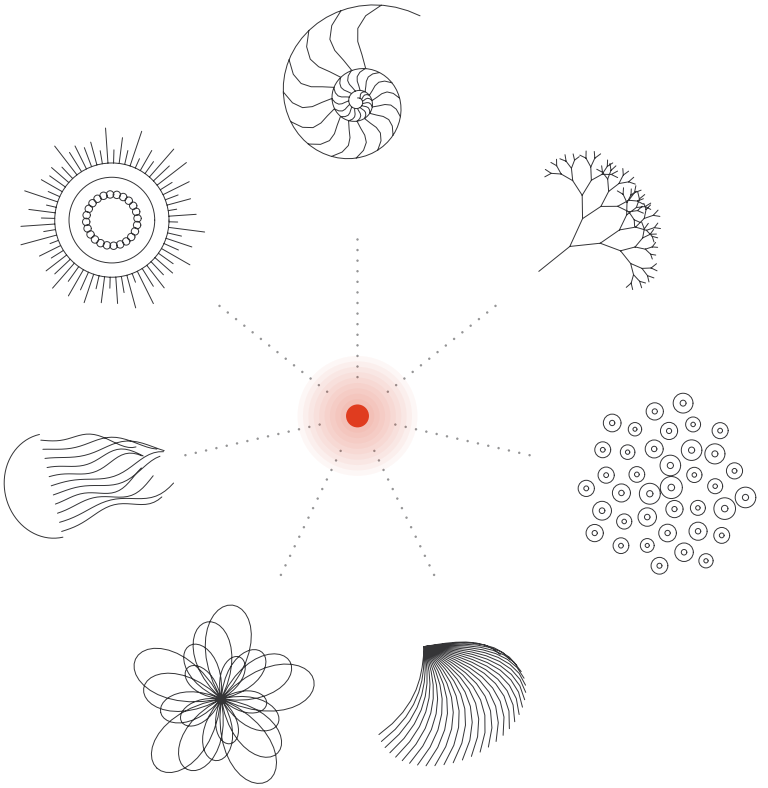
The Upanishads, *Chāndogya Upaniṣad*, c. 6th century BCE. "You are that": each one's self and the absolute are one.

What remains open

If a vaster consciousness guides the lives it gathers, what becomes of each one's freedom?



Consciousness does not begin with us.



So far, we have hardly spoken of anything but human lives. That is a habit, not a necessity. If each consciousness is a part of the Source, nothing allows us to stop the list at our species.

A dog waiting at a door, an octopus exploring a jar with its arms, a crow hiding its food while watching who is looking: year after year, science discovers forms of attention and sensitivity that were denied to animals. It does not say what they live from the inside. It makes it hard to claim that they live nothing.

Each species would be another way for the whole to feel itself exist.

The bat perceives the world through the echo of its cries. The bee sees colours invisible to us. The octopus thinks partly with its arms. None of these experiences is a reduced version of ours: they are other windows, opening onto what we will never see. A Source seeking to know itself would need them all.

For plants, or for an entire forest, the question becomes more uncertain. It would be easy to project a soul onto them as we project a face onto a cloud. This vision prefers to stay modest: it does not know where consciousness begins. It simply does not close the door.

The consequence, however, is concrete. If an animal is also an expression of what we are, its suffering is not a detail. How we treat other living beings would become, very directly, a way of treating ourselves.

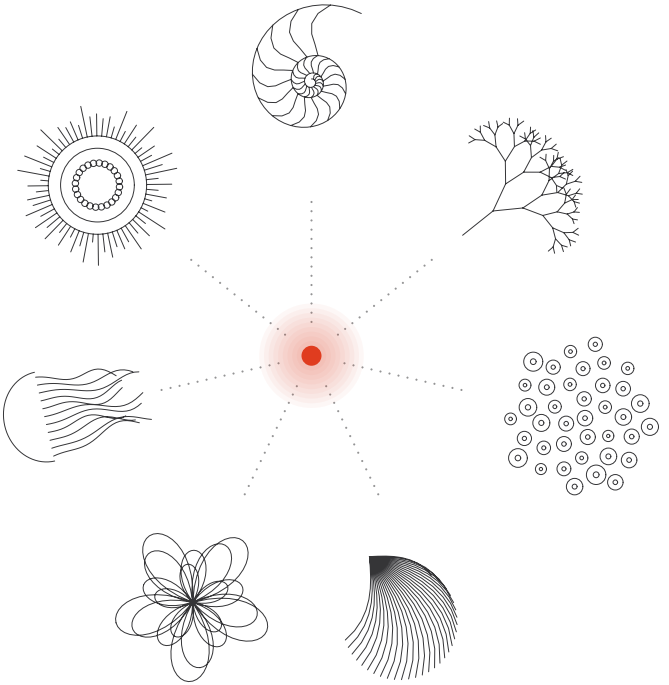
Echoes

Thomas Nagel, *What Is It Like to Be a Bat?*, 1974. One can know everything about an animal without knowing what it is like to be it.

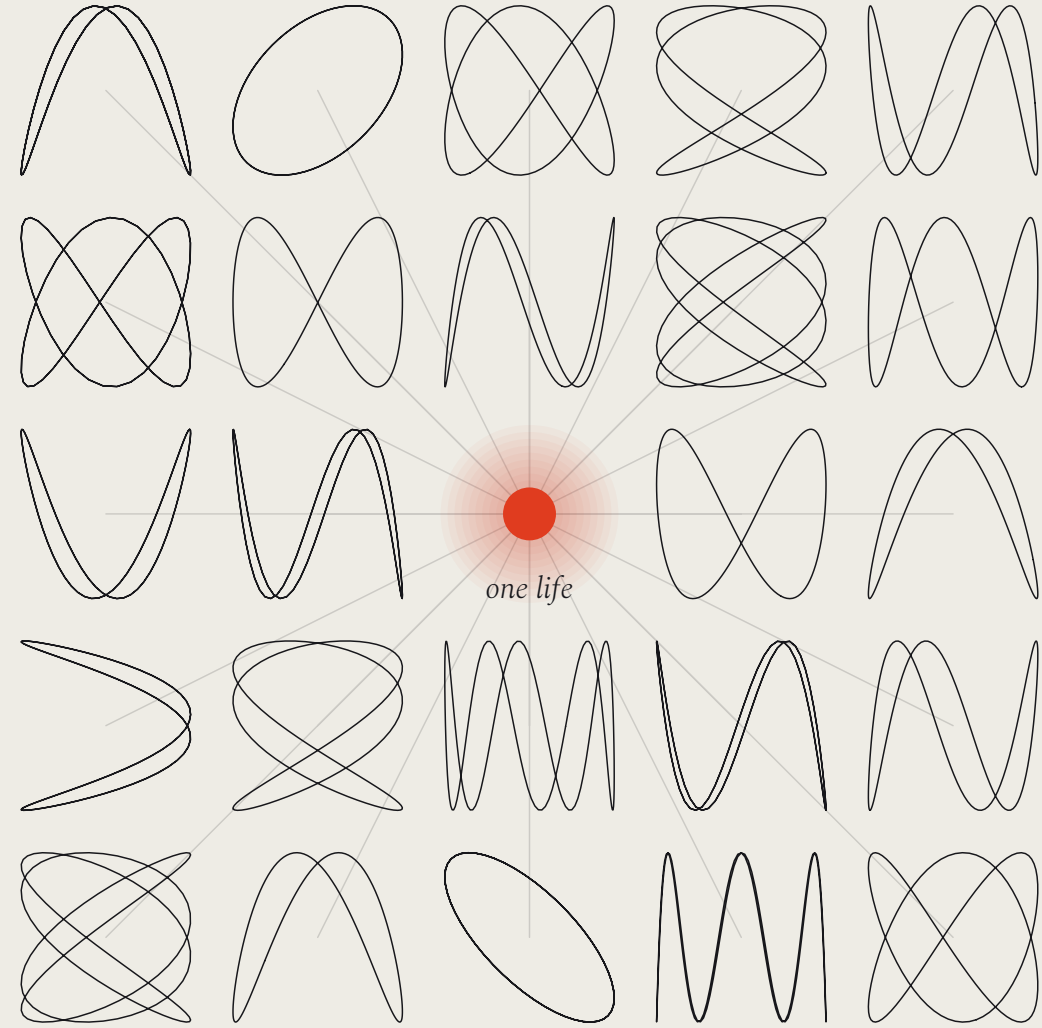
Cambridge Declaration on Consciousness, 2012. Neuroscientists acknowledge that many animals possess the neurological substrates of consciousness.

What remains open

Where does consciousness stop: at the animal, the plant, the cell? This vision cannot draw the line, and does not claim there is none.



A soul could live several existences at the same time.



Take twenty-five lives, to make it concrete. Twenty-five distinct people, each with their own emotions and decisions, knowing nothing of one another. Yet all of them feed a single consciousness.

The parallelism has a purpose: to learn more than a single point of view allows. One life discovers courage, another forgiveness, another attachment.

A familiar image may help. A novelist brings their characters to life each from the inside, with their desires and their mistakes. None of them knows they are the work of another. Yet in writing them, the author discovers things they did not know about themselves. Here there would be no outside author: the soul would be at once the one who writes and the ones who live.

None is a copy of another, and none can be replaced. Each point on the grid sees what the others will never see.

This vision changes how we look at others. The neighbour on the bus, the old woman at the market, the adversary we hate could be, at another scale, close kin: parts of the same effort to understand. Nothing proves it. But it is enough to hold it as possible for indifference to become harder.

The number matters little. Twenty-five, a thousand, or a number no human mind can picture: the figure in this chapter, for that matter, lets the grid run on to the unlimited. What matters is the principle. A single life cannot see everything. Several lives led together see more, and each sees what only it can see.

Twenty-five is an image. Nothing imposes a limit.

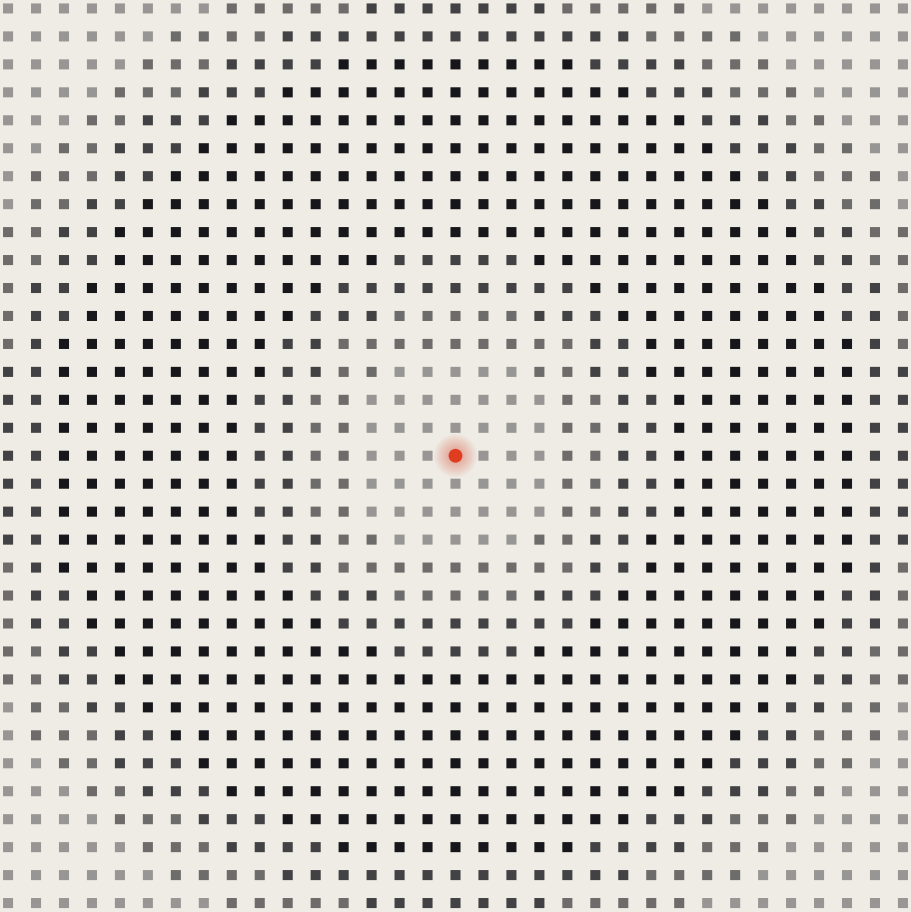
Echoes

Leibniz, *Monadology*, 1714. Each substance mirrors the universe, from a point of view that belongs to it alone.

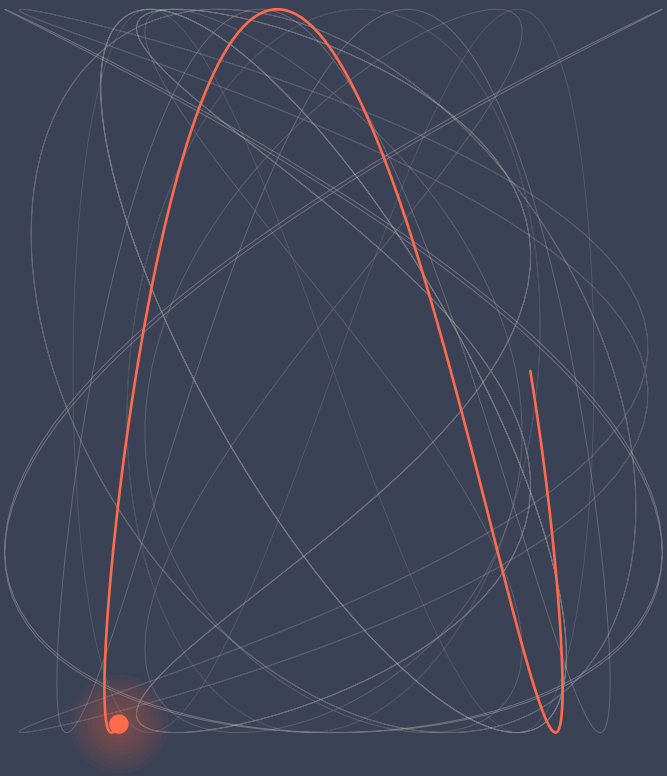
Fernando Pessoa, the heteronyms, from 1914. One poet, several complete authors, each with a life and a body of work.

What remains open

No evidence supports the idea of shared lives. What is it worth, then, as a way of looking at others?



To discover, one must first not know.



It is the simplest objection, and perhaps the strongest. If a soul lives several existences, why does none of them remember the others? No one wakes up with the memory of another language, another face, another death.

The answer most consistent with this vision would be: because memory would make the experience impossible. Knowing is not living, as we will see. A life that remembered all the others would already know too much. It could no longer be afraid for the first time, love for the first time, lose for the first time.

Forgetting would not be a flaw in the journey. It would be its condition.

We know this mechanism on a small scale. An actor who plays well forgets, for the length of the scene, that they are acting. A reader caught up in a novel forgets they are holding a book. These lapses are not failures: they are what make the experience real. The moment the actor watches themselves act, the scene rings false.

Forgetting would then not be a loss, but a veil. What is lived would not disappear: it would be kept at another scale, that of the soul, which gathers what each life does not know of the others. Each existence would write in a book it cannot reread, and which nonetheless loses no page.

Sometimes the veil seems to grow thin. A sense of déjà vu, an unexplained pull toward a place we have never been, the sudden certainty of having always known someone. These experiences prove nothing: memory and the brain explain them very well without any other world. This vision simply finds them a place.

A simpler consequence follows. If each life begins without memory, each begins with the same freedom. No one is a pris-

oner of what they might have been elsewhere. Forgetting, which looks like an injustice, would at bottom be a form of trust: each life is handed a blank page.

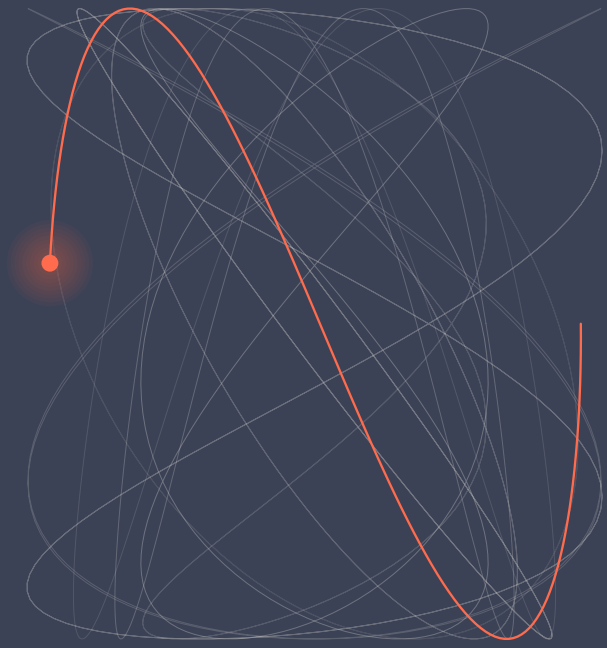
Echoes

Plato, *Republic*, book X. The myth of Er: before being reborn, souls drink from the Lethe, the river of forgetting.

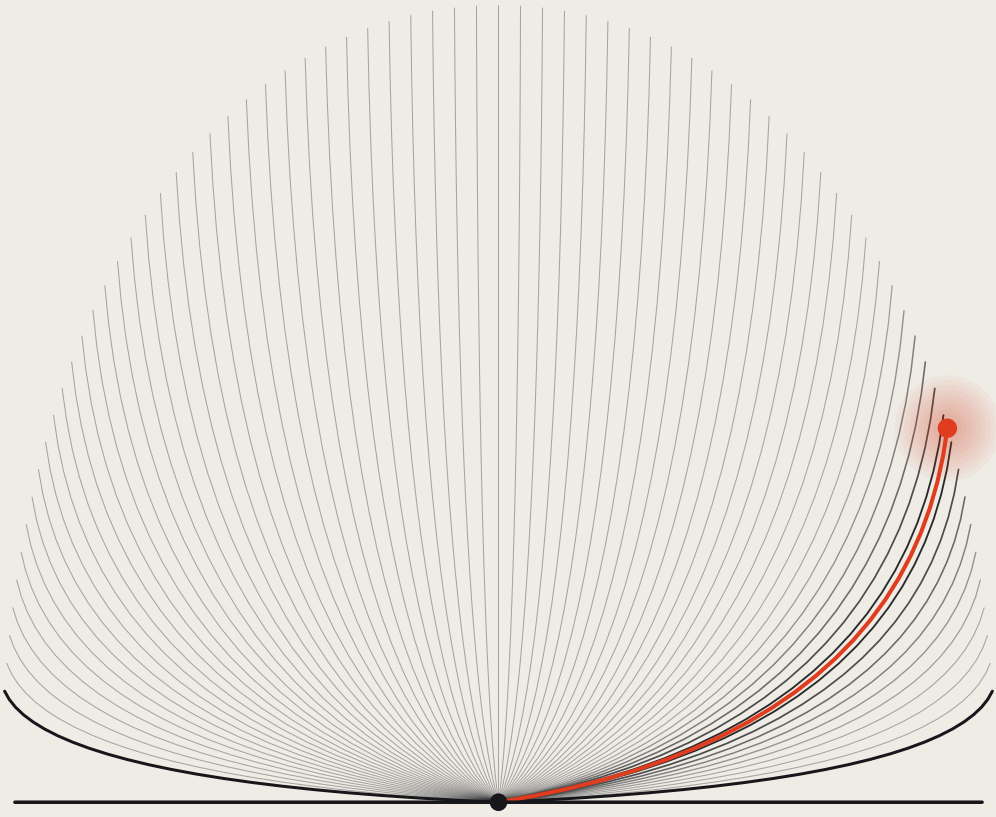
Paul Ricœur, *Memory, History, Forgetting*, 2000. A reserve forgetting, which does not destroy what has been but shelters it.

What remains open

Is a forgetting this complete still distinguishable from there being no earlier lives at all? It is the question this vision cannot escape.

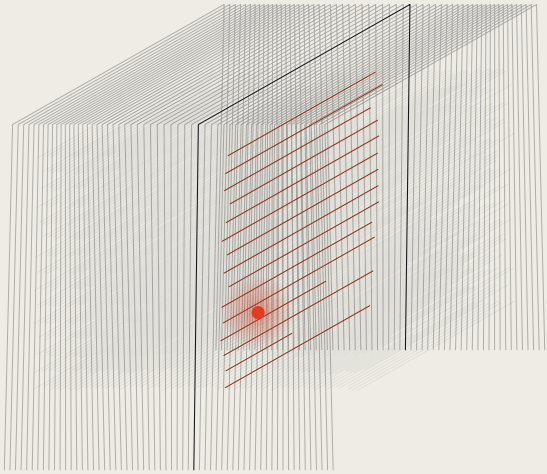


Every page of the book exists at the same time.



We read a book page after page, and that is how we live time. But the reader moving forward does not stop the other pages from being there, together, between the two covers.

Physicists have a similar image. Since Einstein, time is no longer a single river flowing for everyone at the same pace: two events that are simultaneous for one are not for another. Some conclude that past, present and future are equally real, like the places on a map. This is only an interpretation, and a debated one. Yet it shows that the book's intuition is not absurd.



At the scale of a soul, past, present and future could have this simultaneity. Lives separated by centuries would be neighbours: two pages of one volume, which do not read each other.

The past would not be behind us: only on another page.

They would not command one another. What one life understands would simply enrich the whole, and the others would benefit without knowing its source.

A surprising consequence follows. Two lives of the same soul could be separated by centuries, one in the Middle Ages, the other today, and yet nourish each other. What one learns would enrich the whole, from which the other benefits without knowing it. The past would not only serve the present: the present could also, in its way, serve the past.

A certain peace with the past follows from this. What has been lived would not be erased by passing time: the page stays there, whole, even once turned. Happy moments would not be lost. They would simply be elsewhere in the book.

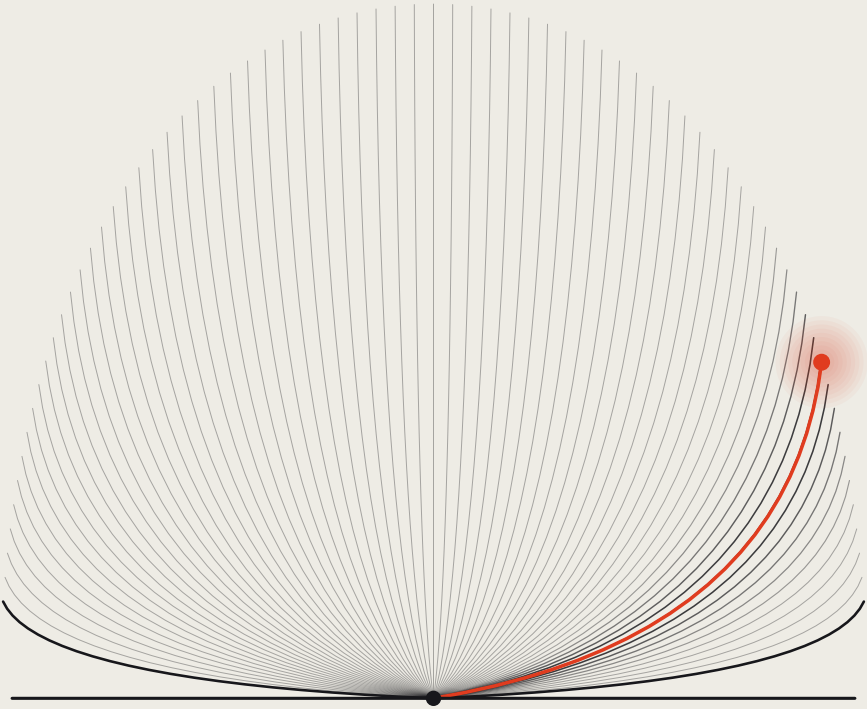
Echoes

Augustine, *Confessions*, book XI, c. 400. Past and future exist only as present to the mind: memory, attention, expectation.

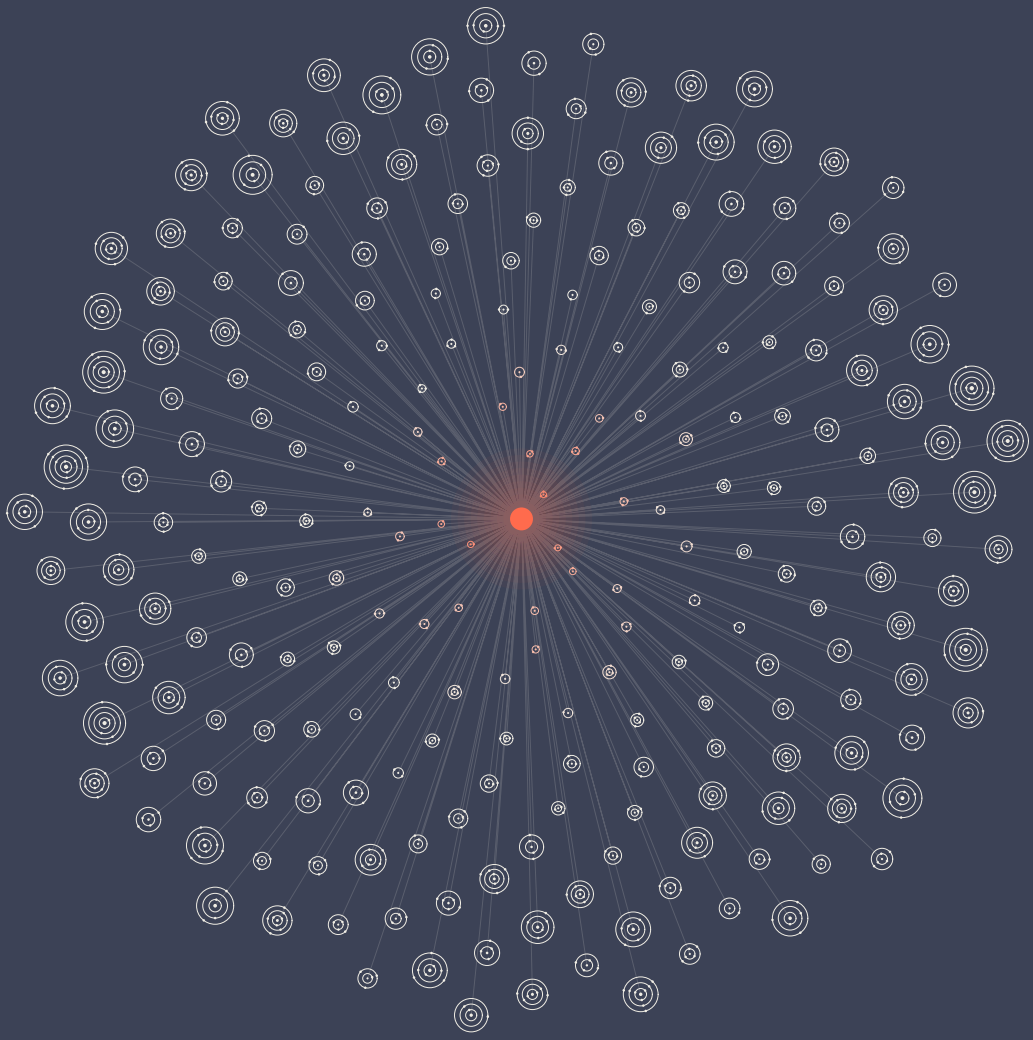
Hermann Minkowski, *Space and Time*, 1908. Time becomes one dimension among four, and a whole history fits on a single line.

What remains open

The book is an image: it does not show that the future already exists. And if all the pages coexist, are they written as they are lived?



A limitless exploration has no reason to stop at one world.



If the Source explores in order to learn, keeping to one planet, one era or one universe would make no sense. Each world would offer other conditions of existence, and so other possible experiences.

Imagining other worlds is not just imagining other planets. It would be imagining other laws, other senses, other ways of being conscious: a world where time is perceived as we perceive space, another where light does not exist and everything passes through vibration. Each would offer experiences impossible here.

The unity of this whole would come not from any resemblance between worlds, but from their shared origin.

Contemporary physics does not rule out this idea. Several theories, still speculative, envisage other universes: regions with different laws, separate bubbles, branches where every possibility is realised. None is proven. They only show that the idea of a single world is no longer self-evident, even for science.

Something would always remain to be discovered.

This multitude could make us dizzy, and make our world seem insignificant. This vision draws the opposite conclusion. If each world matters because it offers what no other offers, then ours matters too. What is lived here, on this planet and in this era, could not be lived anywhere else.

There would then never be a final perfection. Perfection is here neither a starting state nor a point of arrival, but a direction.

Echoes

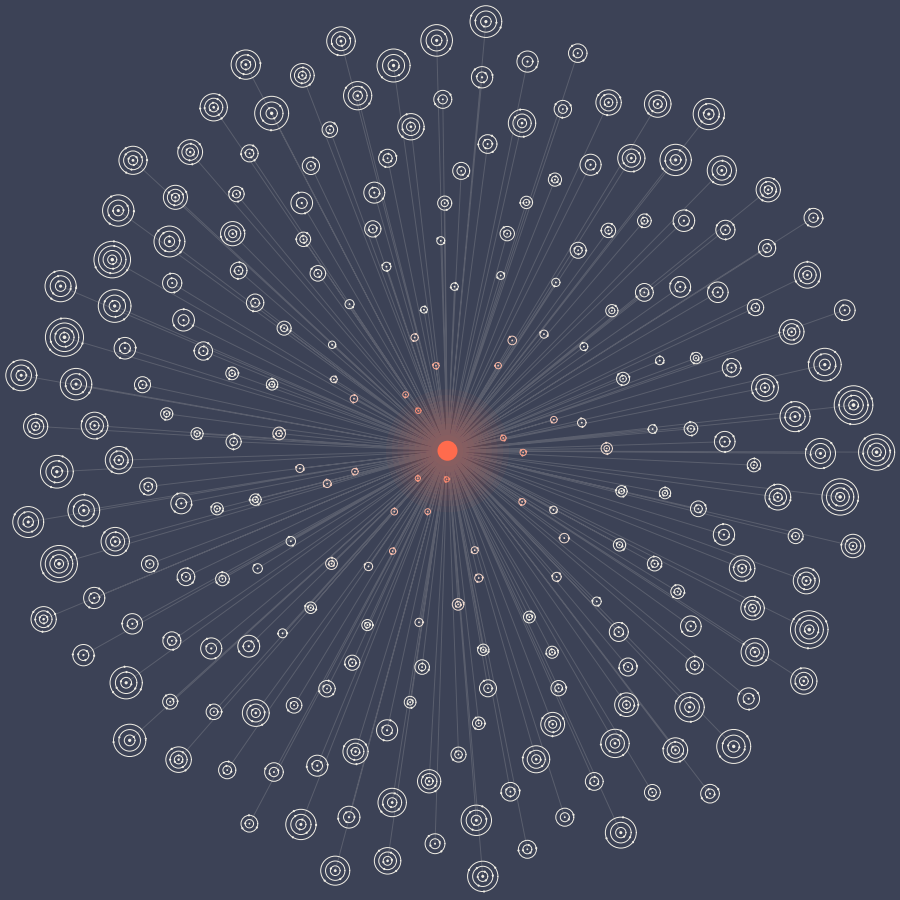
Giordano Bruno, *On the Infinite Universe and Worlds*, 1584. Countless worlds, in a universe without edge.

Hugh Everett, doctoral thesis, 1957. A reading of quantum physics in which each possibility is realised in a branch.

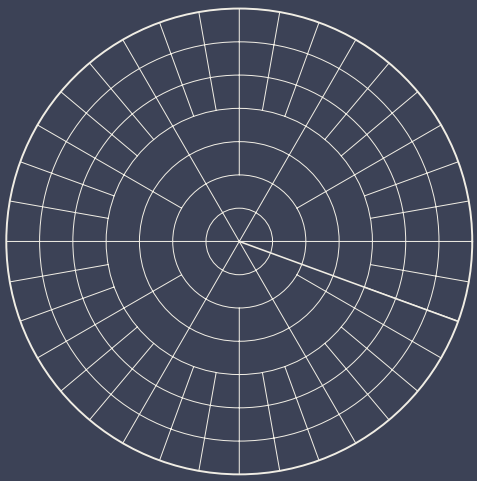
Nietzsche, *Thus Spoke Zarathustra*, 1883. Against those who invent other worlds to console themselves for this one. The counterpoint.

What remains open

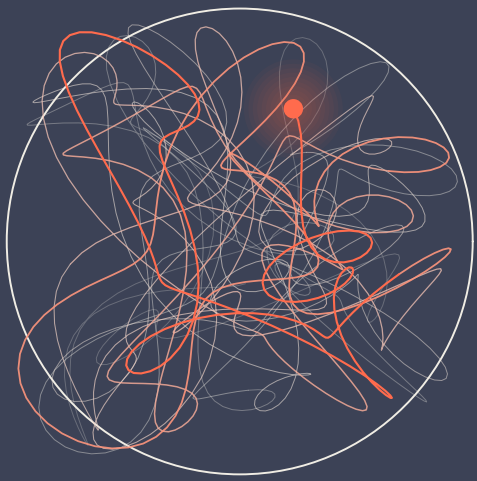
The existence of an infinity of universes has not been demonstrated. And does infinity answer the question, or push it away?



To know is not to live.



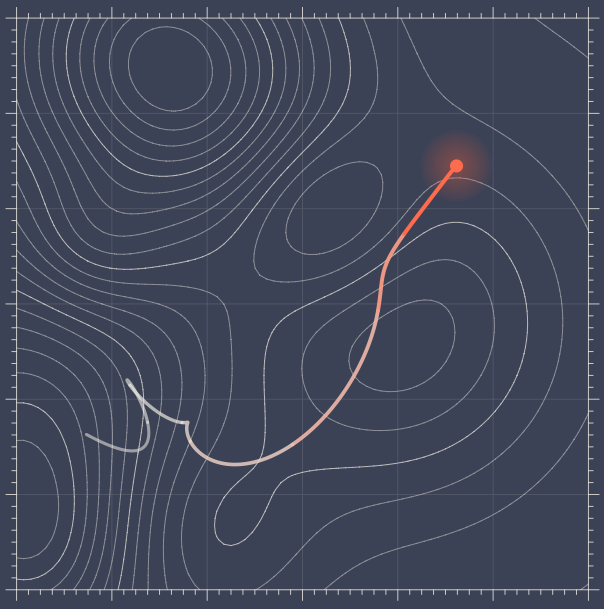
knowing



living

How could something infinite still learn? Because infinite does not mean knowing everything. The Source would contain every possibility, but containing a possibility is not the same as having passed through it.

It could know the definition of love without ever having trembled for someone, and the definition of grief without ever having waited for someone who will not come back. Knowledge would give it the map of everything. It would not give it the weight.



It would lack what only a life can give: once, here, without knowing what comes next.

An existence would then be nothing like a script known in advance. A stranger's ordinary morning, their fear before opening a letter, the taste of a piece of fruit: none of this could be deduced. It could only happen.

We know this difference in our own lives. Reading about swimming does not teach you to swim. Knowing that a person will die does not quite prepare you for the day they do. Between knowing and living, there is always a leap, and that leap can only be made by living.

Perhaps this is why the greatest knowledge prevents neither the naivety of a first love nor the dread of a first loss. It can do nothing about them, and that is not its role. An infinite consciousness would have all the books. It would still lack having been a child discovering snow.

This is also what leaves room for choice, as we will see: a life does not carry out a plan known in advance, it discovers as it goes.

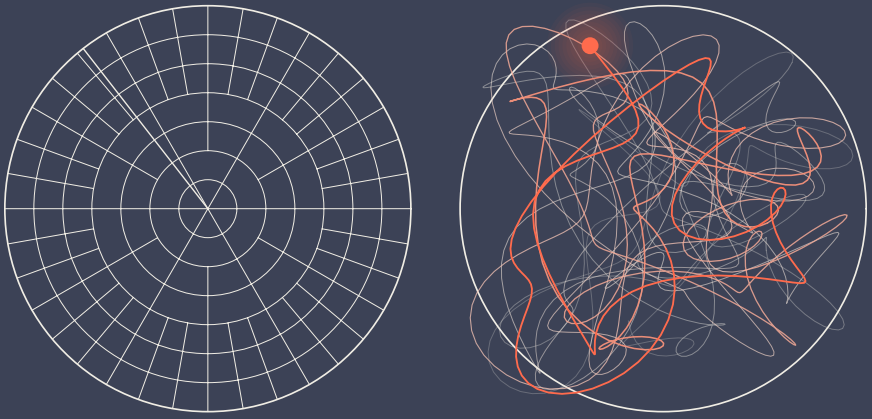
Echoes

Frank Jackson, *What Mary Didn't Know*, 1986. A scientist knows everything about colour without ever having seen it. The day she sees red, does she learn something?

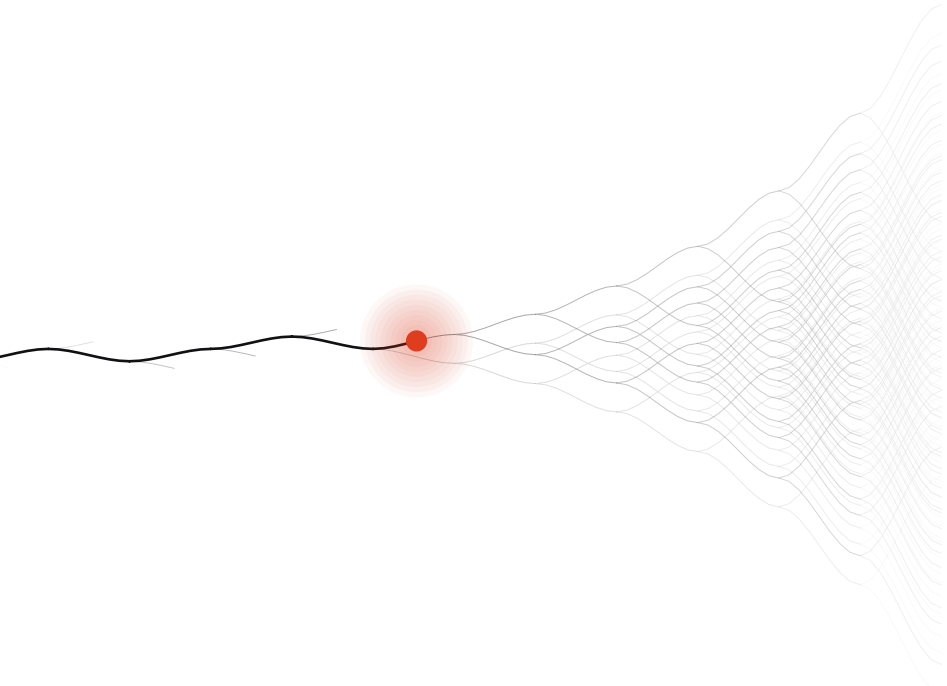
Henri Bergson, *An Introduction to Metaphysics*, 1903. Moving around a thing, or entering into it: two ways of knowing.

What remains open

Does the Source really feel what its forms live through? The model assumes so, without being able to establish it.



No one writes what comes next in our place.



If a vaster consciousness gathers our lives, what is left of our choices? The objection is old: as soon as we suppose a whole, each part seems to become a piece that is moved. The believer wonders how to be free under the gaze of God, the physicist how to be free in a world governed by laws.

This vision answers with what it set out earlier: the Source does not know what comes next. It has no plan that would only need to be carried out. What is decided in a life is truly decided there, and nowhere else.

To be a part of the whole is not to be held by it. It is to continue it.

An image may help. In an orchestra that improvises, each musician listens to the others, tunes to them, lets themselves be carried by what is being played. Yet every note is theirs. The ensemble dictates nothing to them: it gives them a place to play. Without the others, their notes would mean nothing. Without them, the ensemble would not be quite the same.

This does not make us beings without ties. No one chooses their body, their language, their era, or the wounds received before learning to speak. Freedom does not begin in a void. It is exercised in a narrow space, often narrower than we would like, and that is where it counts: in how we respond to what we did not choose.

A quiet responsibility follows. If no one writes what comes next in our place, no one can live it for us either. Each choice, even a tiny one, adds something to the whole that was not there: a way of responding that no other life would have found.

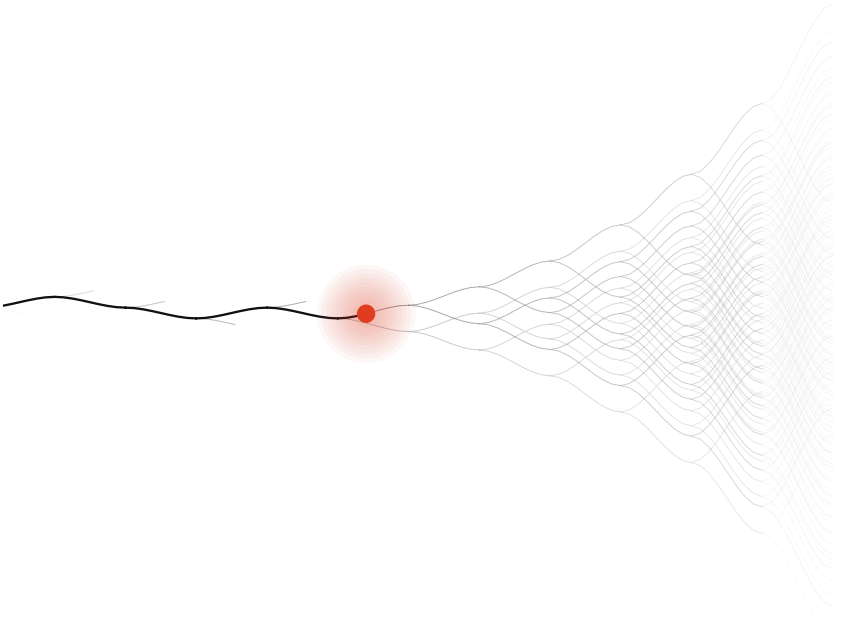
Echoes

Jean-Paul Sartre, *Existentialism Is a Humanism*, 1946. Man is condemned to be free: he is nothing other than what he makes of himself.

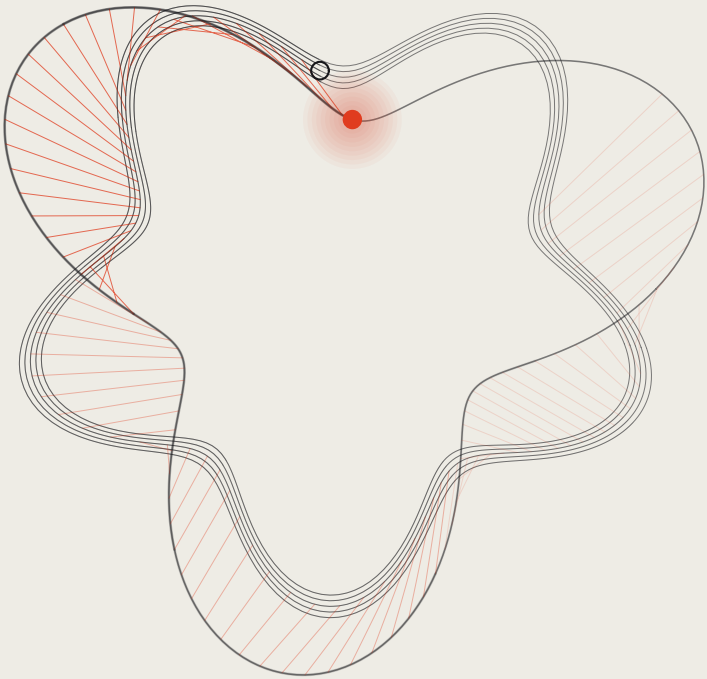
Benjamin Libet, experiments, 1983. Brain activity slightly precedes the conscious decision. The counterpoint.

What remains open

Does the brain decide before we are aware of choosing? Some experiments suggest so, and this vision has no grounds to dismiss them.



To love would be to recognise the whole in someone.



The word comes up often in these pages, without having been looked at squarely. If all consciousnesses are parts of one consciousness, what is it to love someone? A disguised return to oneself? One more illusion?

This vision proposes another reading. To love would not be to erase the distance between two people, but to cross it without abolishing it. We recognise in the other something in common, the same origin, the same ground. And in the same movement, we discover how other they are: their laugh, their fears, the way they hold a cup.

Love would be the only experience in which one is both one and two.

This is why it would be so precious to a Source that learns. Alone, it cannot love: there is no one facing it. It must first have divided itself into a thousand gazes for one gaze to be able to seek another. Love would be separation made fruitful.

It takes countless forms. The impulse of two lovers, the patience of a parent who gets up in the night, the loyalty of a friend who asks for nothing, the tenderness for a stranger met only once. They do not all have the same intensity, but they have the same direction: to go out of oneself without getting lost.

This vision does not make love easier. It makes its failures heavier. If to love someone is to recognise the whole in them, then contempt, indifference and abandonment do not wound only one person. They miss an occasion, for the whole, to recognise itself.

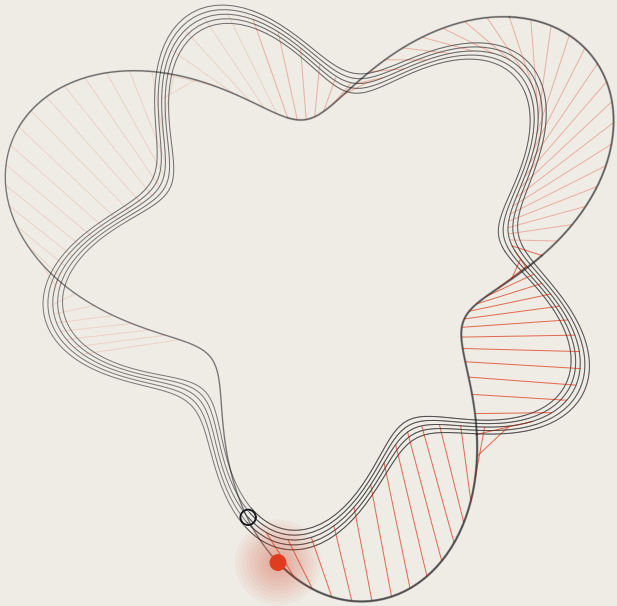
Echoes

Plato, *Symposium*. Aristophanes' myth: each being seeks the half from which it was separated.

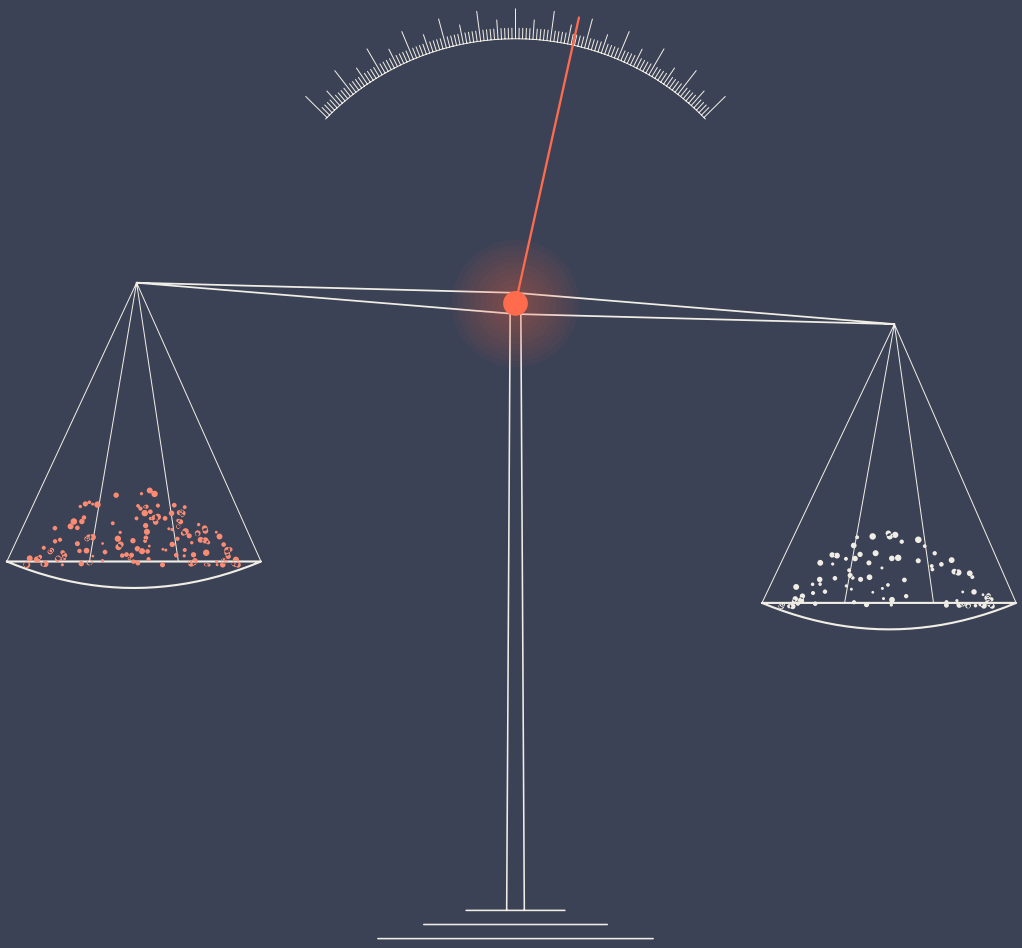
Martin Buber, *I and Thou*, 1923. We truly meet the other only by saying thou to them, never by treating them as a thing.

What remains open

If we are one consciousness, is love not, at bottom, a form of self-love? This vision answers no, without being able to quite prove it.



By exploring, the Source refines its equilibrium.



What does becoming better mean? It is not about climbing from one level to the next: none is worth more than another. It is the whole that adjusts, and no one sets its measure from outside: it takes shape along the way, through what is lived.

The balance holds every polarity: love and fear, creation and destruction, joy and suffering, order and chaos. It never quite settles, since each experience shifts it.

We can see it at the scale of a life. An overly cautious person one day learns boldness, another who is too hard learns gentleness, often at the cost of a trial. No tribunal corrects them: it is a rebalancing, like a walker catching their step. There would be no just final point, only adjustments.

Equilibrium does not require equal amounts of good and evil. It is more like a tuning: learning to reduce suffering without extinguishing the diversity of what can be lived.

This image rules out two temptations. The first would be to want to remove every shadow: a world without fear or loss would offer little to live. The second would be to justify evil in the name of balance. The balance does not ask for there to be suffering. It asks that we learn to produce less and less of it.

The Source does not hold the measure. It is looking for it.

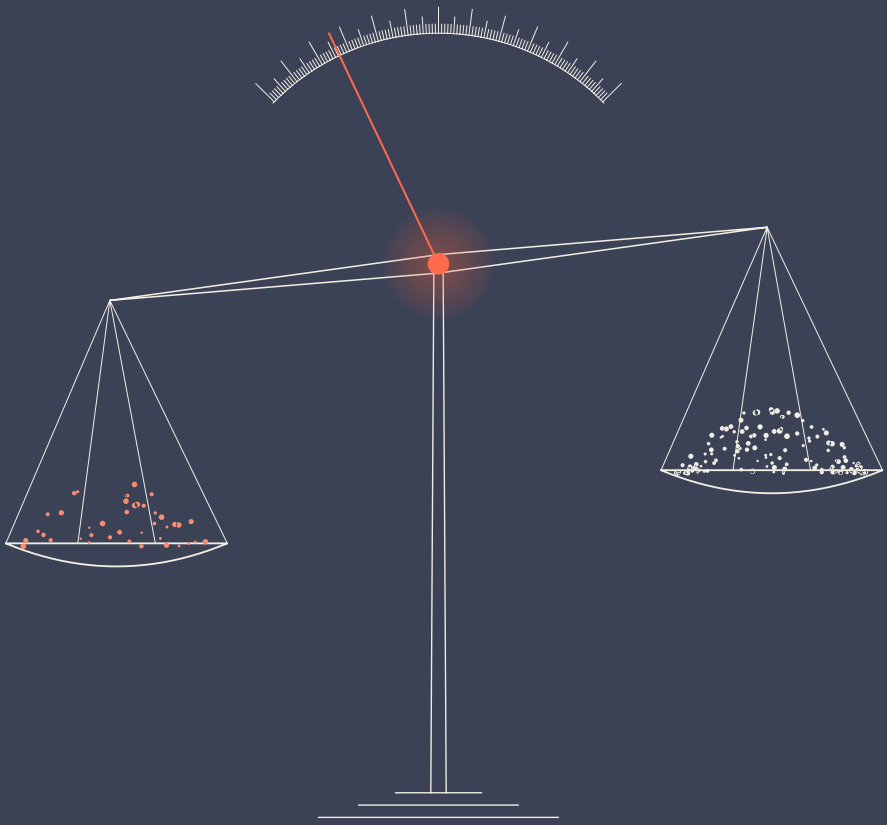
Echoes

Heraclitus, fragments, c. 500 BCE. Harmony is born of opposing tensions, like that of the bow and the lyre.

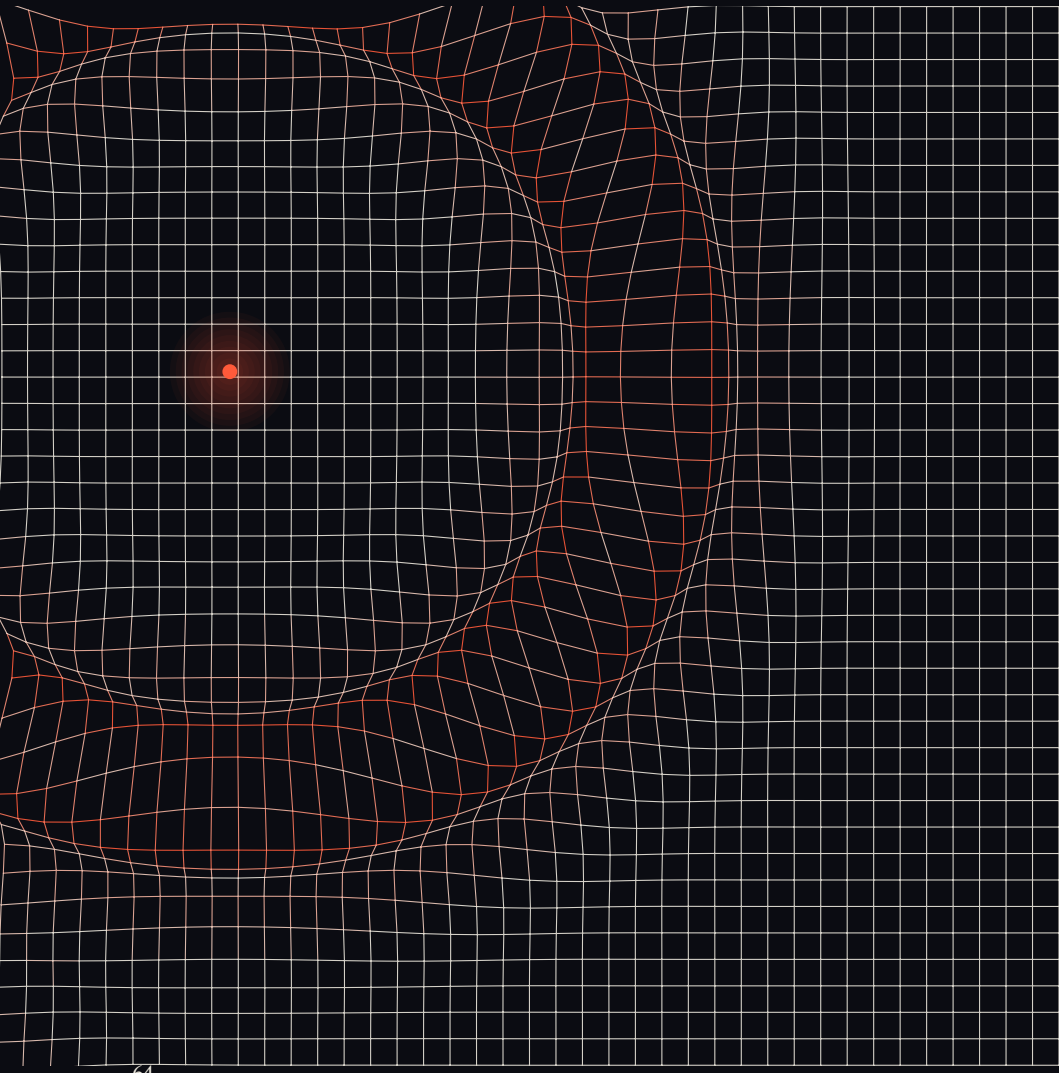
Aristotle, *Nicomachean Ethics*. The right measure is not calculated in advance: it is found in each situation.

What remains open

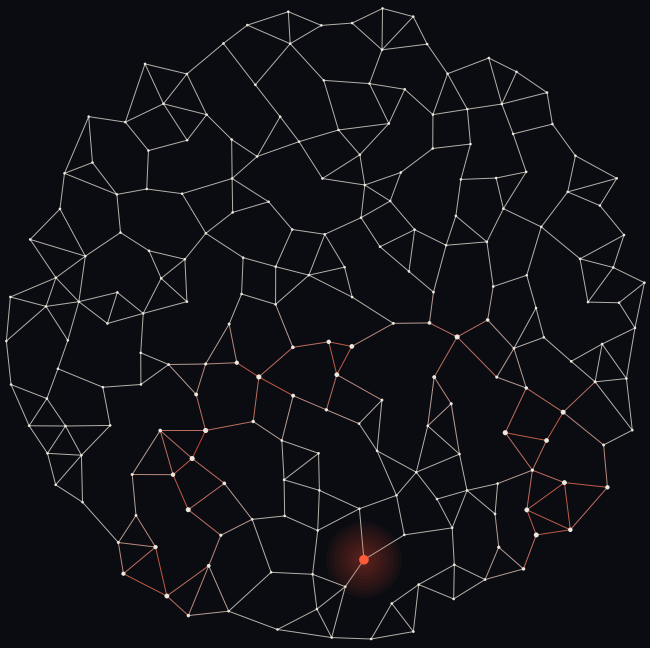
If the criterion of progress evolves along with whatever is progressing, how can progress be recognised?



Nothing that is lived is lived alone.



A hand is burned, and the whole body flinches. If each consciousness is a part of the Source, the same would hold at another scale: no pain would stay local. The Source would not watch suffering from afar: it would undergo it too.



Suffering would therefore not be a punishment. It belongs to what can be lived, and it sometimes teaches something.

We know this, besides, without any metaphysics. One person's suffering never stays enclosed within them: it reaches their loved ones, is sometimes passed down through generations, marks a city or a people. This vision only extends that observation to the end: there would be no place in the real where a pain would fall into the void.

To teach is not to justify.

That limit is not negotiable. No one should tell someone who is suffering that their ordeal had a hidden meaning or was necessary. We also learn through love, curiosity and joy, and pain does not have to become a lesson for a life to have value.

This limit applies to oneself as well. It is tempting to give meaning to one's own trials to make them bearable, and that often helps. But this meaning cannot be decreed from outside or by a theory. It is found, or not, by the one going through the trial, and at their own pace.

A practical consequence follows: doing good to someone is doing good to another expression of what you are.

Echoes

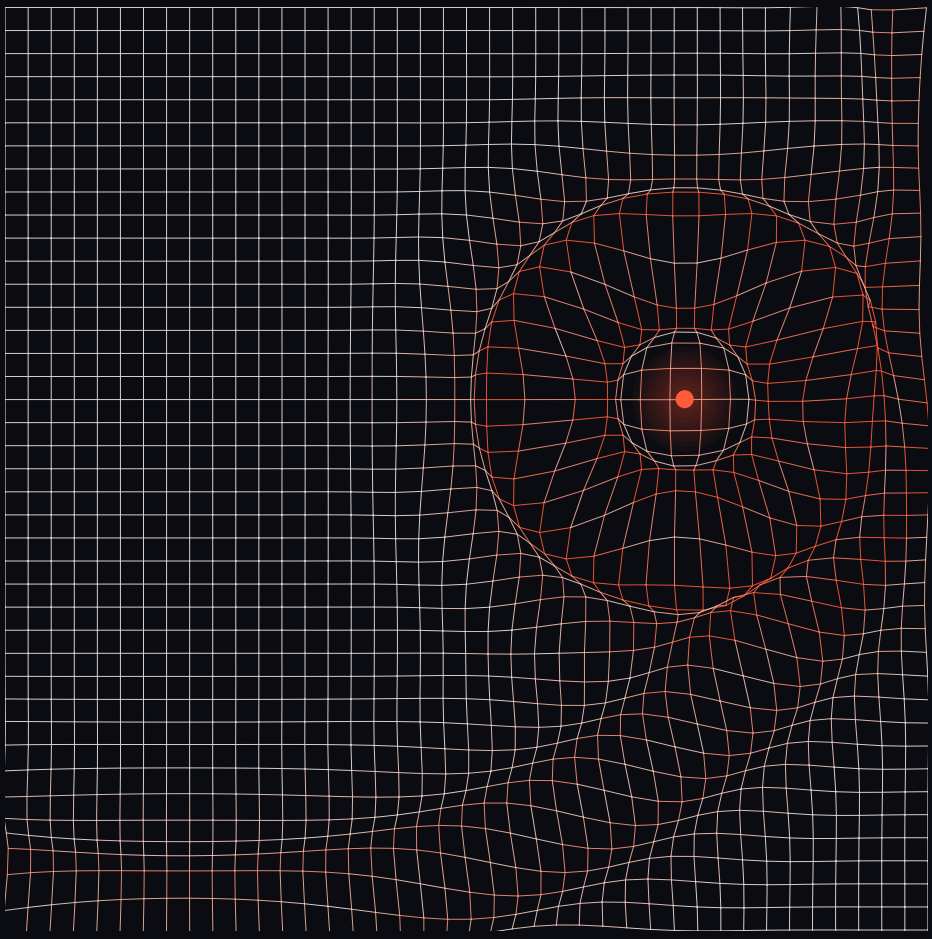
Dostoevsky, *The Brothers Karamazov*, 1880. Ivan refuses any future harmony paid for with the suffering of a single innocent.

Schopenhauer, *On the Basis of Morality*, 1840. Compassion as recognising oneself in the other.

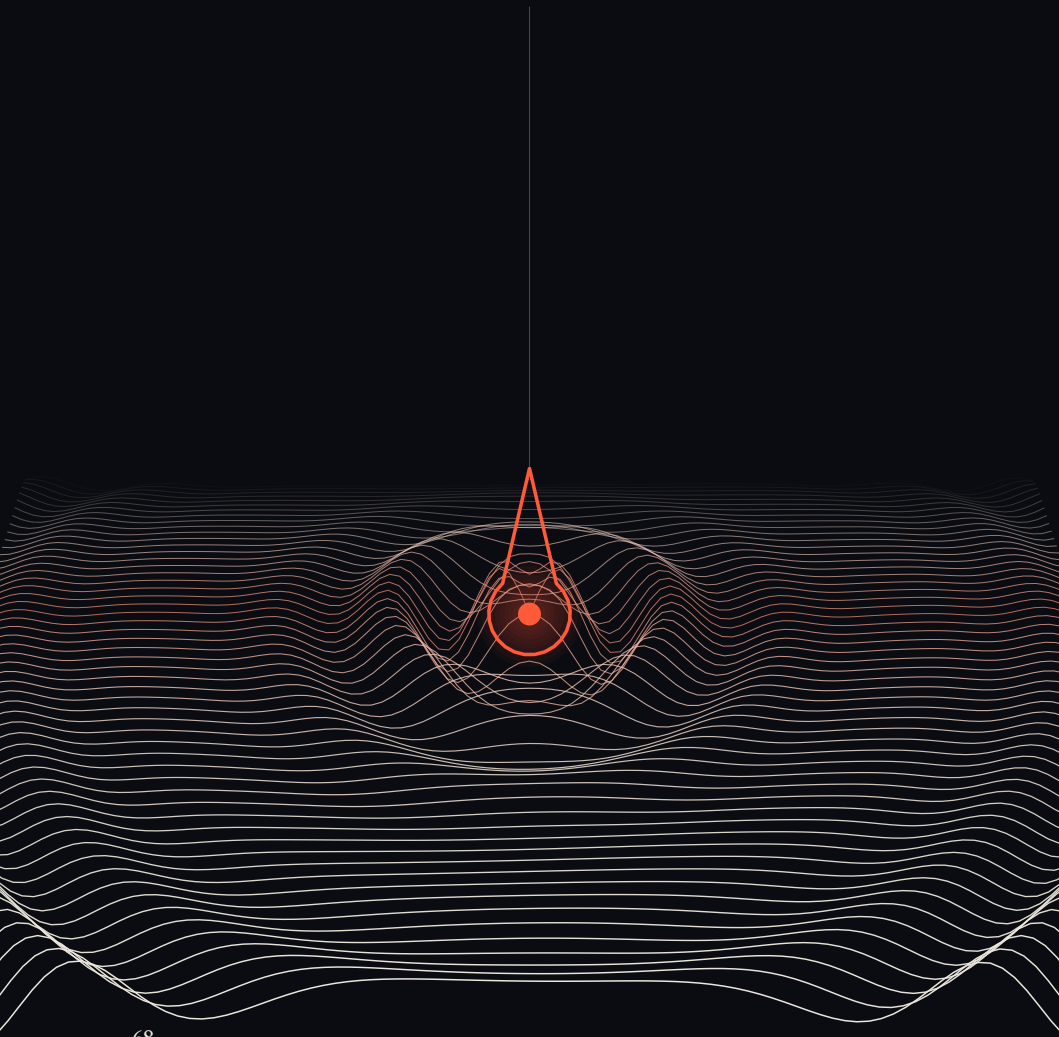
Alfred North Whitehead, *Process and Reality*, 1929. God, "the great companion — the fellow-sufferer who understands."

What remains open

Why would a Source that feels every pain not learn first through love? This is the most serious objection.

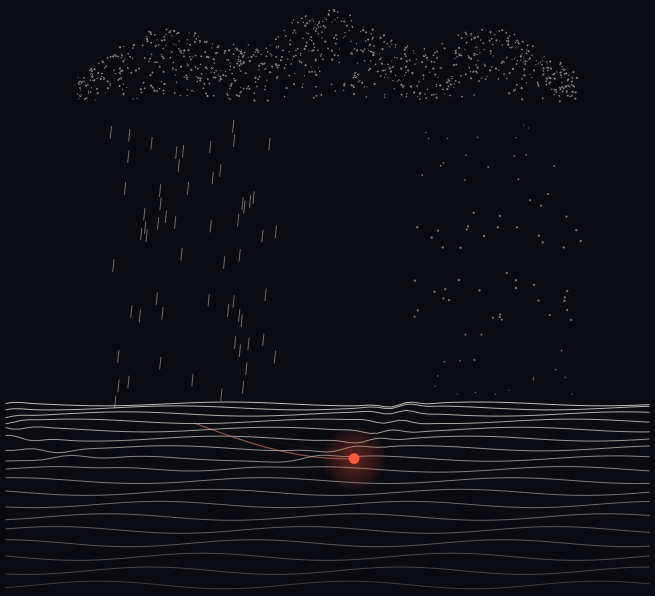


Joining the whole without ceasing to have been yourself.



Must we choose between surviving and merging? The question is often put this way: either you remain yourself, or you disappear into the whole. This vision answers: both.

A drop joins the ocean. It can no longer be found, and yet the ocean is not quite the same: it holds what the drop passed through, the cloud, the rain, the earth.



Death would then be less an end than a change of scale. The life that ends would not go out: it would rejoin the vaster consciousness it was part of, as one comes home after a long journey, with stories to tell. What it learned would become the common good of all it rejoins.

The return is not empty: it brings back everything that was lived.

A consciousness would widen in this way without losing its history, as a distant memory stays whole within a life that has far outgrown it. And what returns sets out again in other forms. The movement has no final stage.

This vision knows nothing of what it is like. It promises neither light at the end of a tunnel nor immediate reunion. It says only that nothing that was lived will have been lived for nothing.

Echoes

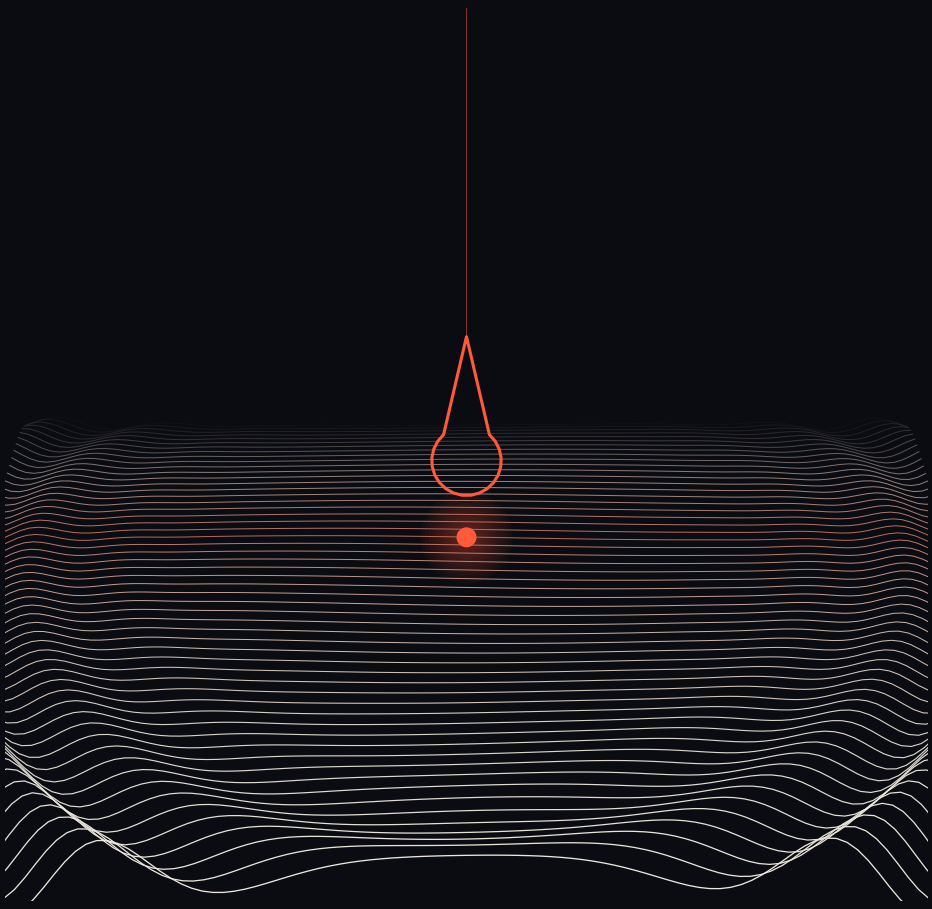
Teilhard de Chardin, *The Phenomenon of Man*, 1955. Union differentiates: by joining a whole, each part becomes more itself.

Spinoza, *Ethics*, book V, 1677. Something of the mind remains, which is eternal.

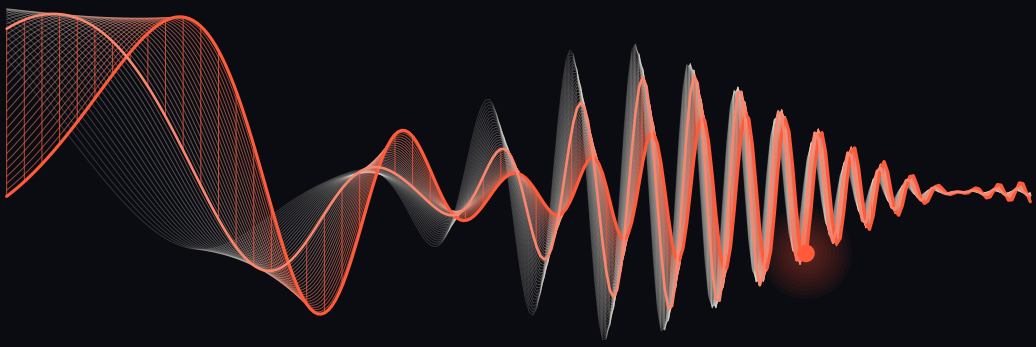
Simone Weil, *Gravity and Grace*, 1947. Decreation: "to make something created pass into the uncreated." A return through the effacement of the self, as a counterpoint.

What remains open

We do not know whether consciousness survives death. And what would have to remain for it still to be you?



One form ends. Life takes another.



Start with what is certain. A person disappears, and their way of laughing carries on in those who loved them. A gesture learned from them comes back to our hands. A phrase they used to repeat slips out of us, years later, in our turn.



This vision takes that observation all the way. Death would not be the opposite of life: there would be life, then life again, in other forms. Those we have lost would go on learning and changing, out of our sight.

This continuity can already be seen in nature. The matter of a fallen tree feeds the soil, and the soil other trees. A dying star sows the elements from which other stars will be made and, one

day, other bodies. Life seems to abhor final endings. It prefers metamorphoses.

Death would end one way of living a bond, not the bond itself.

This takes nothing away from how terrible loss is. Absence remains absence: a voice we will not hear again, a future that will not happen. This vision simply refuses to give it the last word.

This changes how we live a bereavement. We can keep speaking to the dead, not to pretend they are there, but because the bond has changed form without disappearing. Many do so without any theory: a thought before a photograph, a gesture repeated in their memory, a word said under one's breath.

Echoes

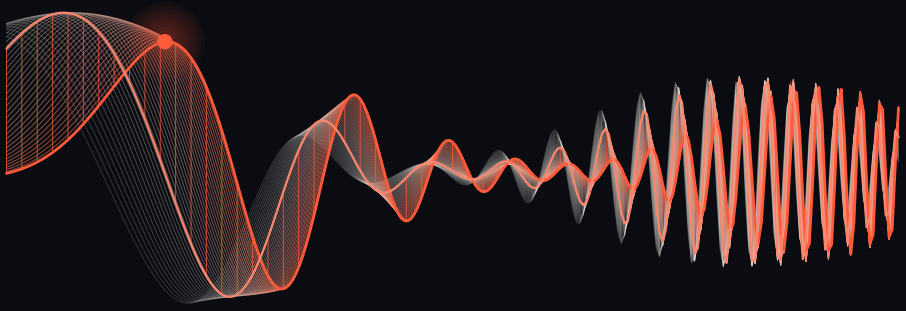
Epicurus, *Letter to Menoeceus*. Death is nothing to us: when it is here, we are not. The firmest counterpoint.

Maurice Halbwachs, *La Mémoire collective*, 1950. The memory of a person lives on in the groups that carry it.

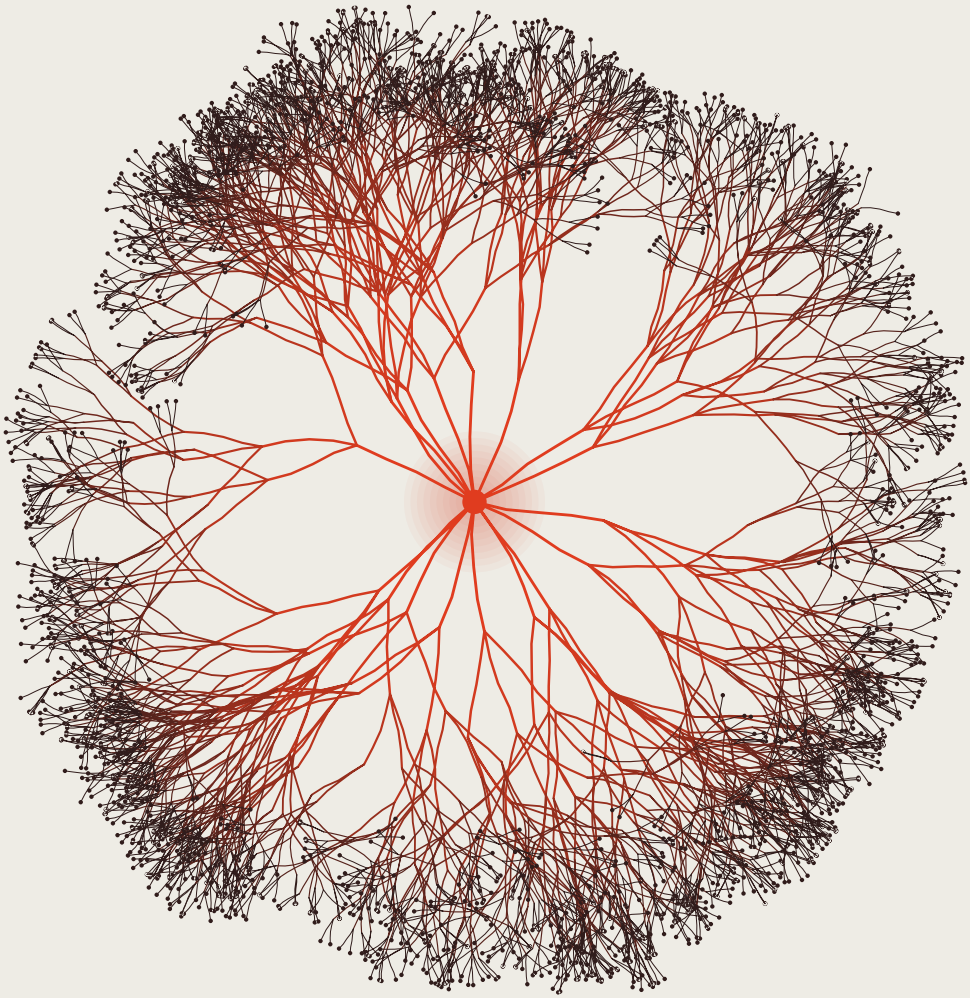
Freud, *The Future of an Illusion*, 1927. A belief born of the wish that it be true. The question to put to any hope.

What remains open

No one can guarantee a reunion. This hope remains a hope, and does not present itself as knowledge.



No existence is useless.



If the Source learns through each consciousness, joys, mistakes, loves and doubts all count. Nothing extraordinary has to be accomplished.

The question of meaning then shifts. It no longer asks only what existence owes us, but what we bring to it.

We often think a life counts in proportion to what it leaves behind: a work, a discovery, a name. This vision measures differently. A life would count first by what it has lived, and no one else could have lived that in its place. A brief, unnoticed existence, forgotten by all, would bring to the whole something as irreplaceable as a famous life.

And it stands even without the Source. Each time we love, help or pass something on, we take part in a story longer than our own life. The effects branch out far beyond what we can follow.

The most modest gestures have a reach we cannot see. A teacher almost never knows what became of their students, or which sentence changed a course. A stranger who helped someone in the street will never know that that day mattered. Most of what we contribute escapes us.

No life has to prove its usefulness in order to have value.

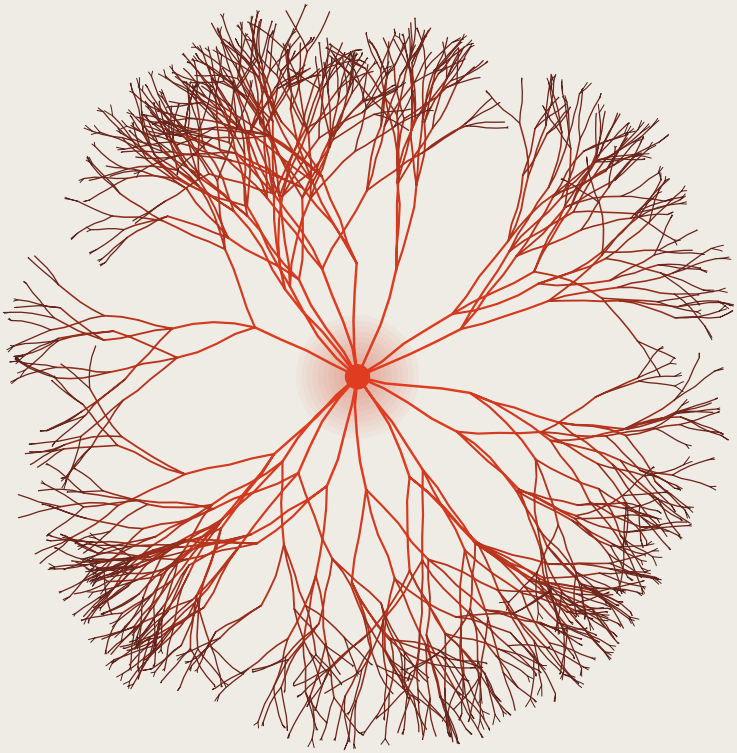
Echoes

Edward Lorenz, lecture, 1972. Does the flap of a butterfly's wings in Brazil set off a tornado in Texas?

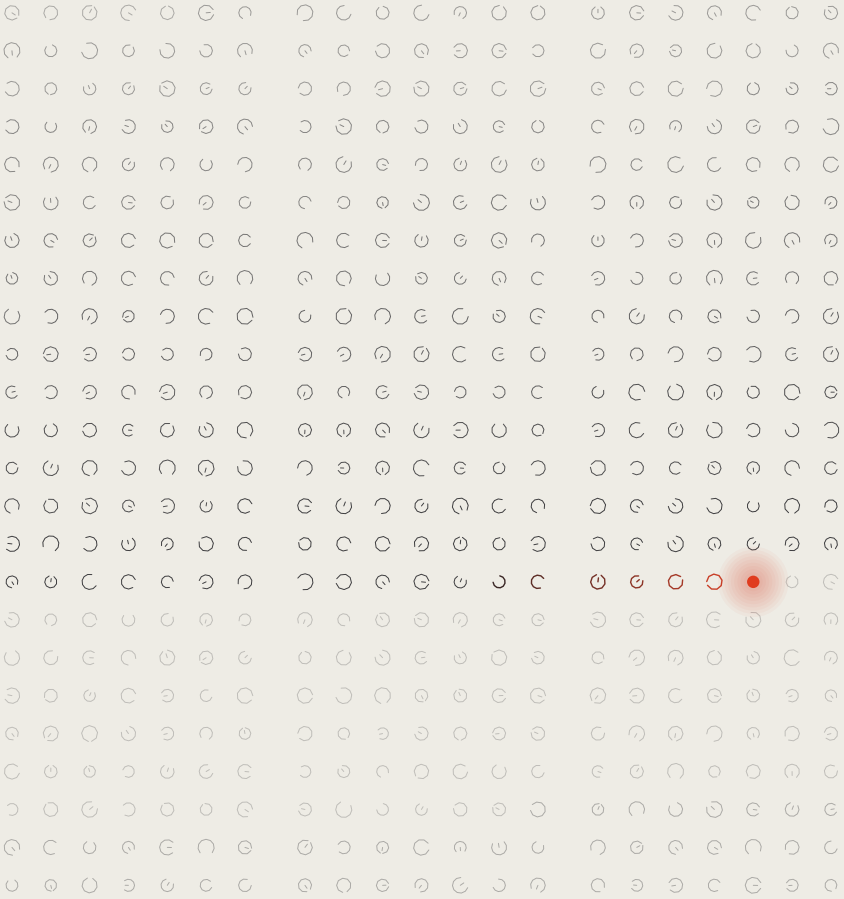
Hannah Arendt, *The Human Condition*, 1958. Every action enters a web of relationships in which its consequences never end.

What remains open

Should a useful life be preferred to a happy one? The model asks without settling it.



Days without a story count too.



We tell lives by their peaks: a birth, a meeting, a loss, a trial overcome. But most of an existence happens elsewhere, in days no one will tell. A bus ride. A queue. An evening when nothing happens.

If the Source learns through what is lived, these days would not be lost time. They would even be what it could find nowhere else. The sublime often resembles itself from one life to the next. The ordinary never quite repeats: the light of a certain morning, the smell of a certain staircase, the tiredness of a certain Tuesday.

There would be no small days. Only days we have not looked at.

Even boredom would have its place. It is hard to love, but it teaches one thing nothing else teaches: bare duration, time when it is filled with nothing. A consciousness that had known only intensity would not know what a Sunday afternoon that never ends is like.

This is not about embellishing routine or pretending everything is wonderful. A life can be crushed by repetition, by meaningless work, by days that resemble each other until exhaustion. This vision does not ask us to rejoice in that. It says only that even those days do not fall into the void.

A form of attention follows. Looking a little better at what is there: repeated gestures, familiar faces, things we no longer see from seeing them so much. Not to make them events, but because they too are the Source living.

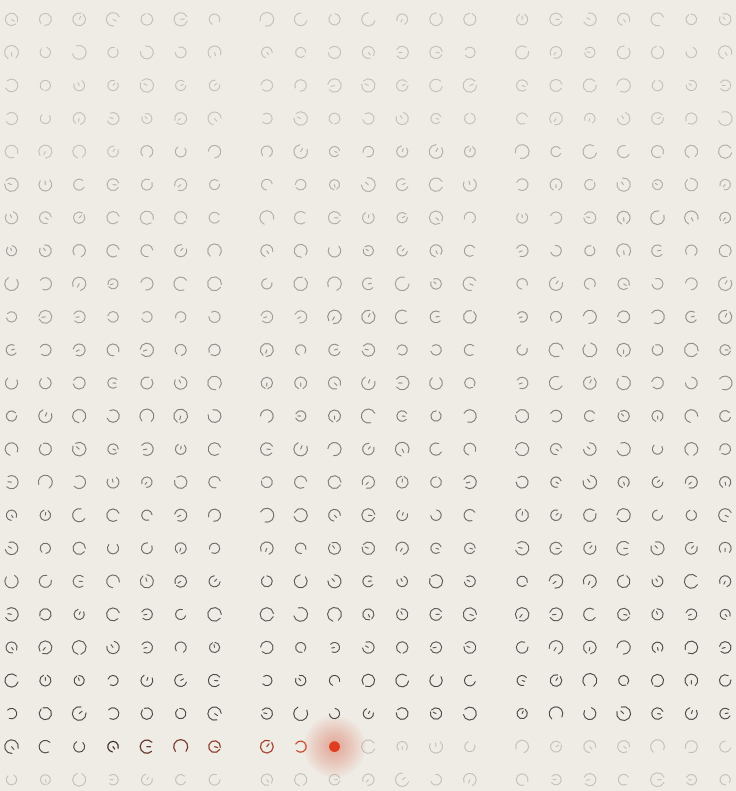
Echoes

Georges Perec, *L'Infra-ordinaire*, 1989. Questioning the habitual: what happens every day and returns every day.

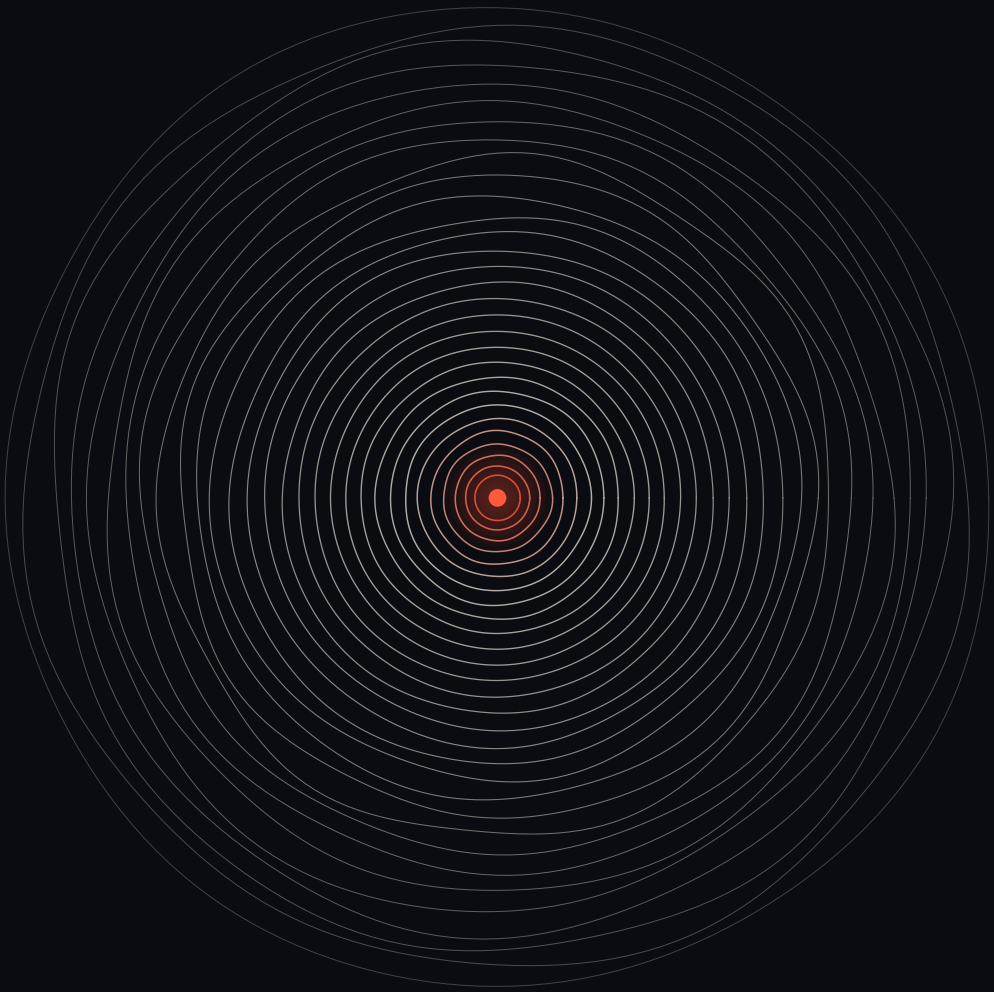
Ecclesiastes, Hebrew Bible. Nothing new under the sun. The weariness of repetition, as a counterpoint.

What remains open

Does a life made mostly of routine have as much value as an intense one? This vision says yes, and that may be its hardest answer to believe.



Sometimes separation falls silent.



Some moments resist words. Before the sea, at the top of a mountain, in a room where someone has just been born or has just died, the border between oneself and the rest may seem to thin. One no longer thinks of oneself. One is simply there, and that is enough.

Contemplative traditions have sought these moments by very different paths: meditation, silent prayer, walking, attention to the breath. Yet they often describe them in the same way. The inner chatter quiets, time expands, and something vaster can be felt.

In silence, the Source would no longer need to search for itself. It would simply be there.

This vision finds them a natural place. If each consciousness is a part of one consciousness, separation would never be complete. It would be a veil, thicker or thinner at different moments. Silence would be the instant when it becomes almost transparent: a foretaste of the return, without the return.

We must nonetheless stay cautious. These experiences can be explained without supposing anything else: a brain relaxing the sense of being a distinct self, an attention that shifts. Their intensity does not prove that they tell the truth. It proves only that they are real for those who live them.

They require neither technique nor belief. A child absorbed in a game, a craftsman focused on a gesture, a walker who stops because the light has changed: everyone knows those instants when one ceases, a little, to be someone. They do not last, and that is as it should be. A life is made to return to noise, to others, to things to do. But it can keep the memory of this silence as one keeps that of a country.

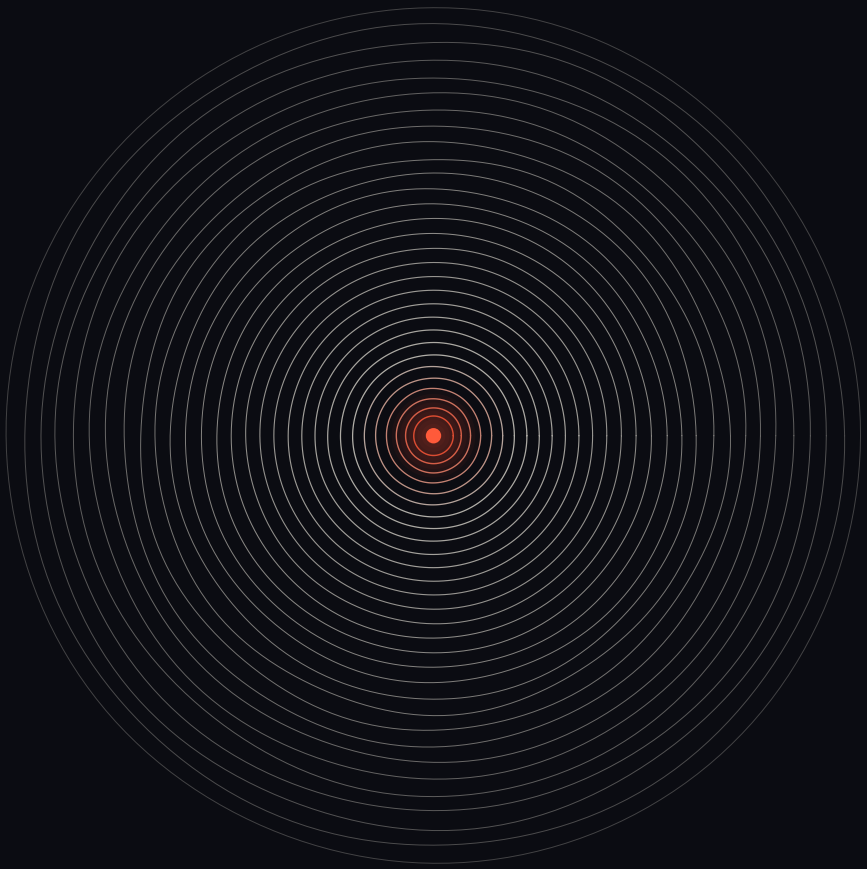
Echoes

Meister Eckhart, sermons, 14th century. The ground of the soul and the ground of God are one and the same ground.

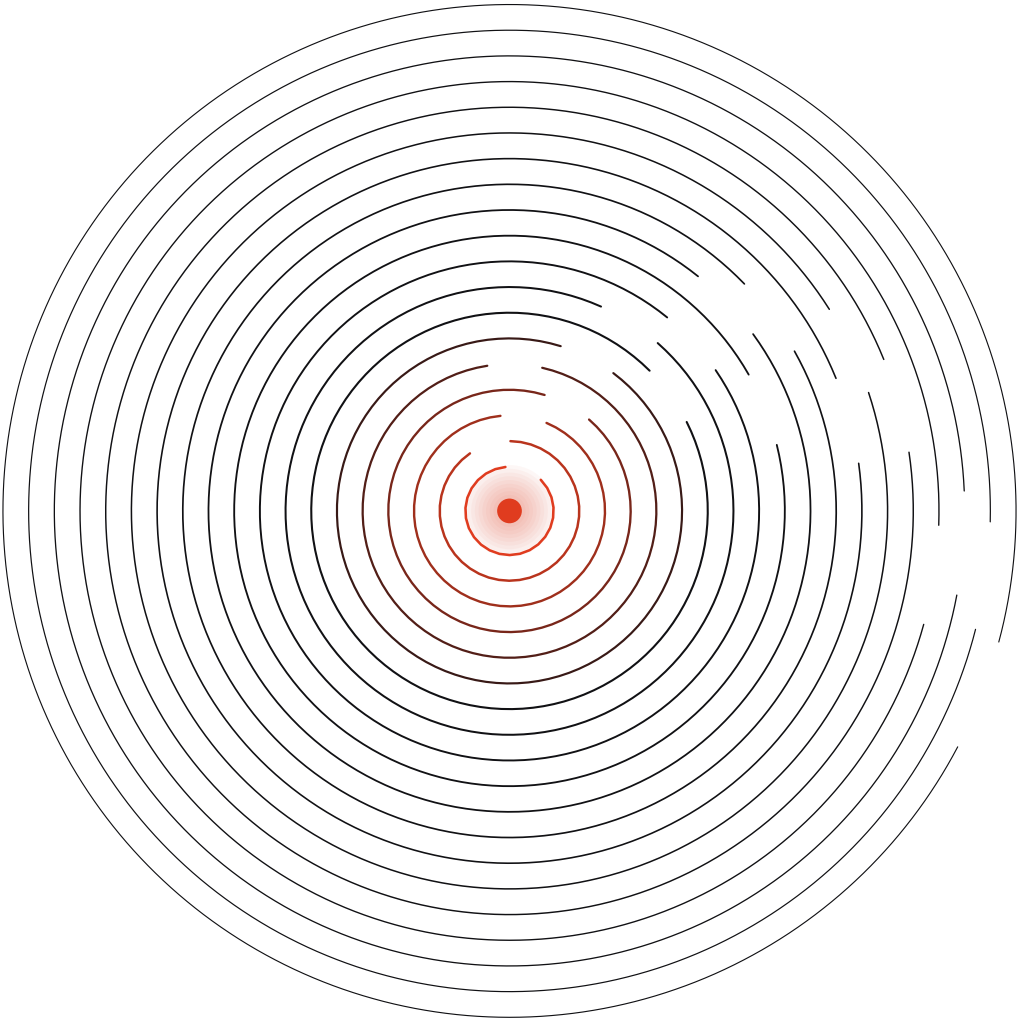
William James, *The Varieties of Religious Experience*, 1902. Mystical states are ineffable, and have for those who live them the authority of knowledge.

What remains open

Do these moments reveal something about the real, or only how our brain works? The two perhaps do not exclude each other, but nothing allows us to decide.



The question is not how, but why.



We can explain how a star ignites, and even how a consciousness might learn. Yet one word is enough to bring the whole edifice down: why?

Learning explains why the Source creates. It does not say why it is. And what if it did not know either? All lives, all worlds would then be a single question, asked in an infinity of ways: why is there something rather than nothing?

The question seems abstract, but it arises in the most concrete moments. Before a newborn child, a starry sky, someone's death, we suddenly wonder why all this exists rather than nothing. The sciences explain how things come about. They do not answer that question, and do not claim to.

The idea enchants and frightens.

It enchants, because no life is a spectator any more: each one takes part in the search. It frightens, because no one, at any scale, would hold the answer.

It may also be that the question has no answer in the sense we mean. Not that it is badly posed, but because the answer would not be a sentence. It would be the totality of what is lived, in every possible way, in all worlds. We would not read it: we would live it.

One firm point remains. No one has ever waited to know the reason for everything before loving someone, sitting up with the sick or planting a tree. Meaning begins before the answer.

Echoes

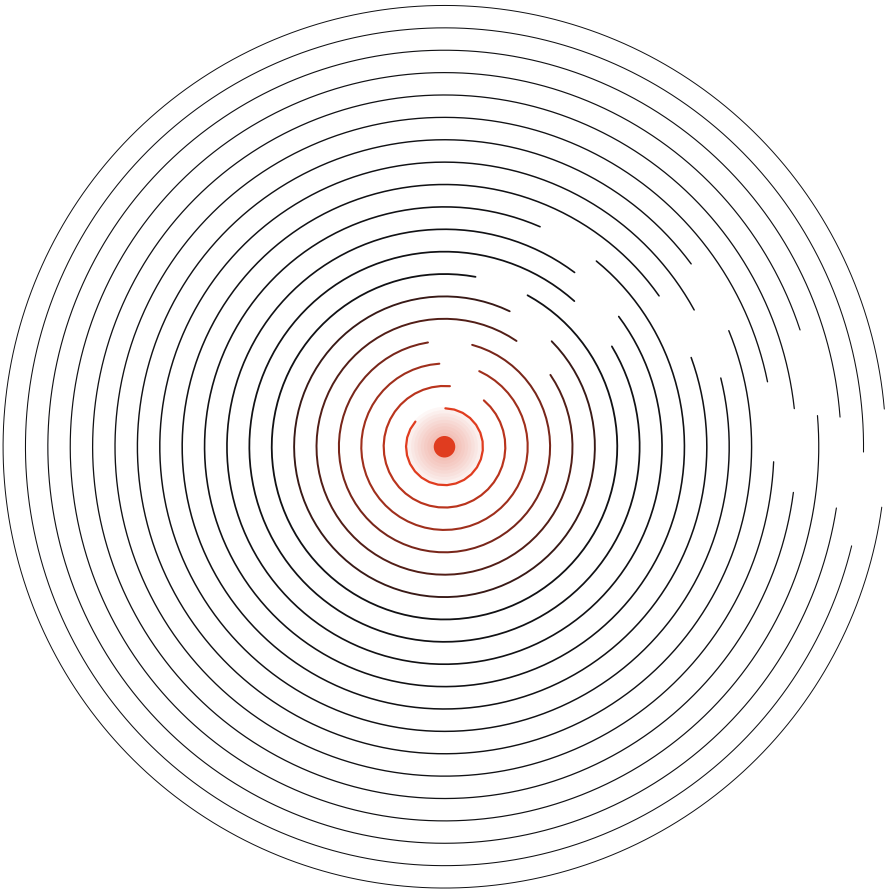
Leibniz, *Principles of Nature and Grace*, 1714. Why is there something rather than nothing?

Rilke, *Letters to a Young Poet*, 1903. Love the questions themselves, and live them, until one day you live into the answer.

Līlā, Hindu thought. The world as the play of the divine, with no reason beyond the play itself.

What remains open

Could an infinity of experiences even provide that answer?



Four questions remain open

If a consciousness directs its lives, how can each one stay free?

If the Source feels every pain, why would it not learn more through love?

If it is searching for why it exists, could an infinity of experiences ever tell it?

If this vision consoles, is that a reason to believe it, or to distrust it?

And one last question, left unanswered.

Has the Source always known it exists, or is it learning this through us?





https://c0sm0cats.github.io/the-source/